

Govt launches talent hunt scheme to explore talents in youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday announced the launch of the 'Talent Hunt Scheme — Hauslon Ki Udaan 2026-27'. The scheme aims to identify and support talented youth in Delhi by providing a national platform. The announcement was made at a press conference at CM Jan Seva Sadan, where the official logo was also released. Minister for Art, Culture, and Languages, Kapil Mishra, attended the event. According to the Chief Minister, the Delhi

Government intends to provide opportunities for young people to demonstrate their abilities. The Department of Art, Culture and Languages will implement the scheme to support youth participation and promote Delhi's cultural heritage. The scheme is designed to encourage diversity and support self-employment and self-reliance. The scheme will be implemented across all 70 Assembly constituencies in Delhi, with a budget of ₹10 crore. It is expected to involve over 25,000 participants. The government stated that the process will be transparent

and phased to ensure equal opportunity. Youth aged 16 to 35 can register free of cost on the online portal www.delhi-talenthunt.com, which will provide registration details and programme updates. The competition features seven major categories: singing (classical, folk, and non-classical), dance (classical, folk, and contemporary), fine art, digital art, sculpture and pottery, music composition, instrumental music, and acting and theatre. The Chief Minister said the programme will be conducted in four phases: online registration and shortlisting; 35 cluster-level competitions;



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, along with Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra, announced the government's 'Delhi Talent Hunt' during a press conference at Civil Lines in New Delhi

four zonal competitions; and a state-level final in August, with 28 finalists. Winners in each category will receive prize money, and all finalists will be recognised. Selection will be based on online public voting, while

THE SCHEME IS DESIGNED TO ENCOURAGE DIVERSITY AND SUPPORT SELF-EMPLOYMENT AND SELF-RELIANCE

the remaining 75 per cent will be determined by an expert jury comprising experienced, reputed professionals from relevant fields. She added that the grand finale will be organised on a large scale, with noted Bollywood personalities and celebrities expected to attend. First-place winners will receive ₹2.5 lakh. Second-,

third-, and fourth-place winners will receive ₹2 lakh, ₹1.5 lakh, and ₹1 lakh, respectively. Selected participants and outstanding performers will also receive certificates, awards, shields, and medals. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the scheme is intended to help Delhi's youth gain recognition at the national level. She stated that selected participants may be considered for roles in future government campaigns. Art, Culture and Languages Minister Kapil Mishra said the scheme is a step towards providing Delhi's youth with opportunities to display their

talent and support self-reliance. He stated that the initiative aims to identify talent and provide guidance and recognition to deserving participants. The entire process, the government said, will be conducted in a transparent, systematic and phased manner to ensure equal opportunity for all participants. Youth between the ages of 16 and 35 can register free of cost through the dedicated online portal www.delhi.talent-hunt.com from Wednesday onwards. The portal will also carry registration details, programme information and regular updates.

Several auto, taxi unions not to support transport strike in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A section of auto-rickshaw unions distanced itself from the proposed three-day strike in the Delhi-NCR region starting May 21, union leaders said on Wednesday. The All India Motor Transport Congress issued a strike call on Tuesday to oppose the Delhi government's decision to hike the environment compensation cess on commercial vehicles. The Delhi Auto Rickshaw Sangh said the auto-rickshaw service will be normal, as the strike pertains to transporters. "The issues concerning goods-carrying vehicles have been ongoing for the past 15 to 20 days and have no con-



nection with auto and taxi drivers. Auto and taxi services will continue to operate normally at all railway stations, bus terminals and other locations as usual," Rajendra Soni, general secretary, Auto Rickshaw Sangh, said. Soni said some unions in Delhi have announced a strike and road blockade; however, five other unions, including Delhi Pradesh Taxi

Union, Auto Drivers Welfare Sangh Delhi, Pragatisheel Autorickshaw Drivers Union and National Capital Region Auto Taxi Transport Union, have distanced themselves from the proposed strike and road blockade. "The unions have demanded that the Delhi government increase auto and taxi fares. The rise in CNG prices has burdened drivers financially," the union said.

LG flags off *jatha* for Sri Hemkunt Sahib Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday participated in the see-off ceremony and flagged off the first 2026 *jatha* for the Sri Hemkunt Sahib Yatra from a Gurdwara Sahib in Rishikesh, joining devotees embarking on the annual pilgrimage to the revered Himalayan shrine. Describing the yatra as spiritually significant for devotees across the globe,

Sandhu said he felt 'humbled' to be present alongside the Sangat as the journey commenced under the guidance of the Panj Pyare. He also recalled his own visit to Hemkunt Sahib with his father, Sardar Bishan Singh Samundri, in 1975. Interacting with the pilgrims, the Lieutenant Governor conveyed his wishes for their safety, good health and spiritual fulfilment during the challenging high-altitude pilgrimage.



GAIL Gas Limited
[A wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL (India) Limited]

NOTICE FOR HIRING OF CONTRACTORS FOR CGD PROJECT

GAIL Gas Limited is desirous to hire experienced contractors/agencies through on the spot Walk-In Selection process for execution of DPNG LMC/GI Works, PE Laying Works, and Direct Marketing Agency (DMA) Services across its Geographical Areas (GAs).

The Walk-In Selection Process shall be conducted at the Venue and Time mentioned below for the following Gas:

SN	GAs	DPNG LMC/GI Works & PE Pipeline Laying Works
1.	Meerut (UP)	22.05.2026, 23.05.2026 & 25.05.2026 10:00 AM to 5:30 PM
2.	Sonipat (Haryana)	
3.	TTZ (UP)	
4.	Dehradun (Uttarakhand)	
5.	Dewas (MP)	

Venue: Conference Room, 3rd Floor, GAIL Gas Limited, GAIL Jubilee Tower, B-35/36, Sector-1, Noida, Uttar Pradesh.

Interested bidders may submit relevant supporting documents, including Work Experience Certificates, GST Registration, PAN, PF/ESI Registration (wherever applicable), and details of available manpower and equipment.

The bidder shall submit a copy of at least one work order, awarded during the last seven (7) years, as proof of experience in carrying out of PNG connection/pipeline-related works in the gas, water supply, drainage, telecom, or any other utility sector for GAIL/GAIL Gas and/or their Group Companies, or for any other company.

Detailed Terms & Conditions shall be available at following link: <https://gailgas.com/eoi/expression-interest>

Contact Persons

- arnab.samanta@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:7055515333)
- saksham.gupta@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:9988092246)
- anil.kumar1@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:7763807378)
- sandeep.sharma1@gail.co.in (Mobile No.:9599477955)

All corrigendum/addendums to this notice will be hosted on the GAIL Gas website only. Hence, you are requested to visit the website regularly.

Corporate Identification Number: U40200DL2008GOH78614

Karnataka Bank Ltd.
Your Family Bank. Across India.

Asset Recovery Management Branch
8-B, First Floor, Rajendra Park, Pusa Road, New Delhi -110 060

Phone : 011-40591567(Ext-231)
E-Mail : delhiarm@ktkbank.com
Website: www.karnatakabank.com
CIN : L85110KA1924PLC001128

SALE NOTICE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with proviso to rule 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to public in general and in particular to Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the **secured Creditor**, the **Physical Possession** of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Karnataka Bank Ltd, the Secured Creditor on 05.06.2023, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on 17.06.2026, for recovery of Rs.84,87,309.15 (Rupees Eighty Four Lakh Eighty Seven Thousand Three Hundred Nine and Paise Fifteen Only) i.e. Under PSDO Loan Account No.553700600004201 along with future interest from 01.06.2024, i.e. Plus Cost, due to the Karnataka Bank Ltd, New Delhi G T Karnal Road Branch, No-6 Jain Colony, Veer Nagar, G T Karnal Road Delhi-110007, the Secured creditor from (1) M/s Avon Elements Pvt. Ltd Represented by its Directors (i) Mrs. Neha Jain W/o Abhinav Jain, (ii) Mrs. Karuna Jain W/o Sandeep Kumar Jain, registered address: No.38/1, First Floor, Govindpur, Opposite Kalkaji Bus Depot, Delhi 110007, (2) Mrs. Neha Jain W/o Abhinav Jain, (3) Mrs. Karuna Jain W/o Sandeep Kumar Jain, Both (2) and (3) are Residing at: House No.11, Second Floor, Veer Nagar Jain Colony, New Delhi 110007, being borrowers/ guarantors/ co-obligants.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY:

All that Part and Parcel of Commercial Property situated at second floor, within a Six Story Building that comprises of Basement, Ground and four more floors (B+G+4), Commercial Complex called as Central Square complex, Measuring Having super area of 853.01 Square feet, Covered area of 498 square feet, Unit/No P-3/224, Plaza-3, Block-A, CSC-20, Manohar Lal Khurana Marg, Bara Hindu Rao, Delhi – 110006, belonging to Mrs. Karuna Jain. Boundaries: East: Open, West: Entry/Corridor, North: Unit No.225, South: Unit No.223 Reserve Price/Upset Price below which the property may not be sold: Rs.62,00,000.00 (Rupees Sixty Two Lakh only)

Earnest money to be deposited / tendered: Rs.6,20,000.00 (Rupees Six Lakh Twenty Thousand Only)

(The borrower's/mortgagor's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured asset).

(This Notice shall also serve as Notice under Sub Rule (1) of Rule (9) of Security Interest Enforcement Rules-2002 to the Borrower/Guarantors)

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to link in Karnataka Bank's Website i.e. www.karnatakabank.com under the head "Mega E-Auction on 17.06.2026".

The E-auction will be conducted through portal <https://bankauctions.in/> on 17.06.2026 from 11:30 A.M to 12:30 P.M with unlimited extension of 05 minutes. The intending bidder is required to register their name at <https://bankauctions.in/> and get the user Id and password free of cost and get online training on E-auction (tentatively on 16.06.2026) from M/s.4closure, 605A, 6th Floor, Maltrivanam, Ameerpet, Hyderabad-500038, Contact No.-991-8142000066, 0915160064 E-mail: info@bankauctions.in.

Date : 20.05.2026
Place : New Delhi

Sd/- For Karnataka Bank Ltd
Chief Manager & Authorised Officer

Karnataka Bank Ltd.
Your Family Bank. Across India.

Asset Recovery Management Branch
8-B, First Floor, Rajendra Park, Pusa Road, New Delhi -110 060

Phone : 011-40591567(Ext-231)
E-Mail : delhiarm@ktkbank.com
Website: www.karnatakabank.com
CIN : L85110KA1924PLC001128

SALE NOTICE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with proviso to rule 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to public in general and in particular to Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the **secured Creditor**, the **Physical Possession** of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Karnataka Bank Ltd, the Secured Creditor on 27.02.2023, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on 17.06.2026, for recovery of Rs.33,50,640.85 [Rupees Thirty Three Lakhs Fifty Thousand Six Hundred Forty and Paise Eighty Five Only] under i.e. (i) Rs.30,47,337.83 under PSDO A/c No.558700600002401 along with future interest from 01.12.2024 (ii) Rs.3,03,303.02 under PSDPN A/c No.5587001400002201 along with future interest from 28.11.2024, plus cost, due to the Karnataka Bank Ltd., Karol Bagh Branch, Plot No.5439/71, Ground Floor, Main Aya Samaj Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005, the Secured creditor from (1) M/s Elite Advertising & Marketing, represented by its proprietor, Mr.Arun Makkar S/o Mr. Har Bhagwan Das addressed at: Unit No.26, 1st Floor, CSC No.1, A- Block, Sec-16, Near Mother Dairy, Rohini, Delhi- 110086 (2) Mr. Arun Makkar, S/o Mr. Har Bhagwan Das, addressed at: #G1/183-184, 2nd Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089 (3) Mrs. Charu Makkar, W/o Mr. Arun Makkar addressed at #G1/183-184, 2nd Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089, being borrowers/ guarantors/ co-obligants.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY:

All that part and parcel of Commercial Property Shop/Unit Bearing No.26, situated on First Floor, Block-A, CSC-1, Sector-16, measuring 8.57 sq.mtrs., Rohini, New Delhi- 110089, belonging to Mrs. Charu Makkar. Boundaries: East : Shop No.24, West : Shop No.28, North : Shop No.27, South : Open

Reserve Price / Upset Price below which the property may not be sold: Rs.12,60,000.00 (Rupees Twelve Lakh Sixty Thousand only)

Earnest money to be deposited/ tendered: Rs.1,26,000.00 (Rupees One Lakh Twenty Six Thousand Only)

(The borrower's / mortgagor's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured asset).

(This Notice shall also serve as Notice under Sub Rule (1) of Rule (9) of Security Interest Enforcement Rules-2002 to the Borrower/Guarantors)

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to link in Karnataka Bank's Website i.e. www.karnatakabank.com under the head "Mega E-Auction on 17.06.2026".

The E-auction will be conducted through portal <https://bankauctions.in/> on 17.06.2026 from 11:30 A.M to 12:30 P.M with unlimited extension of 05 minutes. The intending bidder is required to register their name at <https://bankauctions.in/> and get the user Id and password free of cost and get online training on E-auction (tentatively on 16.06.2026) from M/s.4closure, 605A, 6th Floor, Maltrivanam, Ameerpet, Hyderabad-500038, Contact No.-040-23836405, Mobile 8142000809, E-mail: info@bankauctions.in.

Date : 20.05.2026
Place : New Delhi

Sd/- For Karnataka Bank Ltd
Chief Manager & Authorised Officer

AXIS BANK

Retail Assets Centre, Axis Bank Ltd. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301. Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor and first floor, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi – 110001 • **Corporate Office:** Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhakar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025 • **Registered Office:** Trishul, 3rd floor, opposite Samartheswar Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

DEMAND NOTICE

Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned herunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFAESI Act, 2002 calling upon the following borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.

Name of the Borrower / Address / Co-borrower and Guarantor Name: 1. M/s. KVMM Trade 340 Udyog Vihar Phase VI, Sector 37 Pace City, Gurugram Haryana-122001 (Borrower) 2. Mr. Vikas H Mandavia B 175A Sushant Lok, Phase 01, Gurugram Haryana-122001 (Guarantor) 3. Mr. Vaibhav Mandavia B 102 Parvayaran Complex Saket, Saidul Azab, Mehrauli South Delhi-110030 (Guarantor) 4. Mrs. Khushboo Mandavia A 175 A Sushant Lok Phase 01 Haryana Gurugram-122001 (Guarantor) 5. Mr. Vansh Mandavia B 102 Parvayaran Complex Saket, Saidul Azab, Mehrauli South Delhi-110030 (guarantor) 6. M/s. mandavia Clothing Pvt. Ltd. Plot No. 340, Phase VI, Gurugram, Haryana-122001 (Corporate Guarantor/Mortgagor) **Property Address of Secured Assets:** All That Part And Partial of Industrial Unit No. 340, Situated At Phase-VI, Gurgaon, Udyog Vihar, Sector-37, Gurgaon, District Haryana – 122004. North – As Site Plan, West – As Site Plan, South – As Site Plan

NPA Date	Date of Demand Notice	Loan Sanctioned Limit	Outstanding Amt (Rs.) as on :
01.05.2026	Notice: 08.05.2026	Amount (Rs.) 24,37,00,000/-	Rs. 13,37,78,580.26

Name of the Borrower / Address / Co-borrower and Guarantor Name: 1. M/s. Limra Enterprises H-21, Sector-9, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh-201301 (Borrower) 2. Mr. Mohamamd Shoaib S/o Mohammad Anis R/o B-200, Sector-108, G. Nagar Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh- 201301 (Co-borrower) **Property Address of Secured Assets:** All that piece and parcel of Plot/Unit Number No. 93, Area Measuring 93 Area Measuring 1000 Sq. Mtrs. in Block -B Situated Within The Industrial Area At Sector -east-36, Greater Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar U.p., Together With Buildings And Structures Therein, Fixtures, Fittings And All Plant And Machinery Attached To The Earth Or Permanently Fastened To Anything Attached To The Earth, Both Present And Future.

NPA Date	Date of Demand Notice	Loan Sanctioned Limit	Outstanding Amt (Rs.) as on :
05.05.2026	Notice: 15.05.2026	Amount (Rs.) 3,70,00,000/-	Rs. 3,74,62,371/-

In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (where ever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and the applicable rules thereunder. Kind attention is invited to provisions of sub-Section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act where under you can tender the entire amount of outstanding together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank only till the date of publication of the notice for sale of the secured asset(s) by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s) Please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no Borrower shall, transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.

Place: Noida U.P. **Date:** 21.05.2026 **Sd/-** Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Nidhi Mittal W/o Shri Anil Mittal R/o Rana Colony, Opposite Navin Saggi Mandi, Dadri, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-203207, hereby inform that on 15.05.2026, some pages of my property documents/sale deeds were lost in the Preet Vihar, Delhi area. These include the last page of Sale Deed dated 15.09.2018 and the second page of Sale Deed dated 26.03.2003 executed in favour of Mr. Vinod Kumar and Mr. Vijendra Kumar. If anybody finds the said documents, kindly return them within 7 days.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the general public that the Original WILL of Late Mrs. Anjali Chatterjee, relating to the residential property situated at E-269 B, Sec. 22, Noida, has been lost/misplaced. A Lost Report regarding the same has already been lodged with Delhi Police vide LR No. 814714/2023 dated 23/08/2023 at P.S. Crime Branch, Delhi. As per the said WILL registered in the office of the Sub-Registrar-III, NOIDA, in Book No. III, Volume No. 1, pages 47-62 as document no. 63 dated 17.01.2020, Late Mrs. Anjali Chatterjee had bequeathed her said residential property in favour of Shree Shree Ma Anandamayee Ashram, Delhi. If any person finds that said Original WILL or has any information regarding it, kindly contact immediately at the details mentioned below:

Name: Sandip Dutta
C/S DA, Hauz Khas, New Delhi-16
Email: ssas.kalkaji@gmail.com
If any person has any objection, claim, or concern regarding the said WILL, they are requested to inform in writing within 15 days from the publication of this notice, failing which no claim shall be entertained thereafter.

Sandip Dutta

केनरा बैंक Canara Bank
आता भक्त का उभार
A Government of India Undertaking
सिस्टीम सिंडिकेट Syndicate

VIKASPURI BRANCH, NEW DELHI-110018
PH-7903307945,9718693112
Email: cb2455@canarabank.com

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

SALE NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described movable/ immovable property mortgaged/hypothecated charged to the Secured Creditor, the **Symbolic possession** of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the **Canara Bank**, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is basis" on below mentioned dates through E-Auction under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, read with Rule 8(6) & 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer the link "E-Auction" provided in **provider (M/s PSB Alliance (Baanknet.com), (Contact No. 8291220220, Email: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com) or Canara Bank's website www.canarabank.com**, EMD amount of 10% of the Reserve Price is to be deposited in E-Wallet of <https://baanknet.com> portal directly or by generating the Challan therein to deposit the EMD through RTGS/NEFT in the account details as mentioned in the said challan.

Name and Address Borrower/ Guarantor	Brief Description of immovable Property	Total Liabilities (Rs.) : Reserve Price (Rs.) : EMD (Rs.) : Increment Amount (Rs.) :	Date & Times of Auction Contact Person Name
1.Mrs. POONAM SHARMA W/O Mr. PRAVEEN SHARMA(BORROWER) ADD:-PLOT NO. 70, FIRST FLOOR, POCKET-9,SECTOR-22, ROHINI, SULTANPURI C BLOCK NEW DELHI, PIN CODE - 110086	All the part & parcel of Property bearing no	Rs. 48,90,535.60 as on 26.03.2026 Rs. 91.00 Lakh Rs. 9.10 Lakh EMD Should be Deposit on 15.06.2026 up to 5.00 PM	12.06.2026 between 16:30 PM TO 01:30 PM (With unlimited extensions of 5 minutes duration each)
2.Mr. PARVEEN SHARMA S/O Mr. SATPAL SHARMA (CO-BORROWER) ADD:- PLOT NO. 70, FIRST FLOOR, POCKET-09 SECTOR-22, ROHINI, SULTANPURI C BLOCK, NEW DELHI, PIN CODE - 110086	All the part & parcel of the Residential property at Entire First Floor (without Roof/Terrace Rights), Part of Freehold Built Up property bearing No. 70, Pocket - 9, Sector-22, Situated in the layout plan of Rohini Residential Scheme, Rohini, Delhi-110086 Measuring:- 90.00 sq. mtr. Boundaries:- (As per Sale Deed) East:- Plot No. 71 West:- Plot No. 69 North:- Service Lane South:- Entry	Rs. 1,00,000/-	Mr. Karuna Pati Pandey (CHIEF MANAGER) (Mob7903307945) VIKASPURI BRANCH, NEW DELHI-110018

Date : 20.05.2026
Place : Delhi

For Canara Bank
Authorised Officer

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002. Hereinafter Called "ACT"

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. FARUKH KHAN S/O MR. HANIF H. No.9/3176, First Floor, Gali No.4, Dharampura, Gandhi Nagar, East Delhi-31 Also At: 9/183, Banaridas Building, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-110031. Also At: F K Enterprises, 9/2189, Gali No.9, Kailash Nagar, Delhi-110031. Also At: K-31, Top Floor, K - Block, Near Ghondli Chowk, Delhi-110051. Car Loan A/c No.: 44694524233	Make & Model: MAHINDRA SCORPIO - N D AT 2WD ZBL 7S Vehicle No.: DL 10DA 9187 Engine No.: YGS4K83375 Chassis No.: MA1TJ2YGT56L60301	07/05/2026 Date of N.P.A. 02.05.2026	Rs.21,81,231/- (Rupees Twenty One Lakh Eighty One Thousand Two Hundred Thirty One Only) as on 07/05/2026 plus further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets. The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

DATE: 20.05.2026
PLACE: NEW DELHI

Sd/- Authorized Officer (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

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Name: Sandip Dutta
C/S DA, Hauz Khas, New Delhi-16
Email: ssas.kalkaji@gmail.com
If any person has any objection, claim, or concern regarding the said WILL, they are requested to inform in writing within 15 days from the publication of this notice, failing which no claim shall be entertained thereafter.

Sandip Dutta

Government to replace 96,000 street lights with smart LEDs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved a major ₹473 crore project to replace nearly 96,000 street lights across the capital with smart LED lighting systems, aiming to improve road safety, eliminate dark spots, and reduce electricity consumption. The decision was taken during a meeting of the Expenditure Finance Committee, chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, on May 20.

The project will cover roads maintained by the Public Works Department and is expected to be completed

before Diwali. Officials said the plan includes replacing old High-Pressure Sodium Vapour lights and outdated LED fixtures with advanced smart LED systems equipped with real-time monitoring technology.

Chief Minister said the project would significantly improve lighting conditions on Delhi's roads and strengthen public safety, especially for women. She said the current lighting system suffers from several shortcomings, including delayed repairs, uneven illumination, and high electricity usage.

"The goal is to remove dark spots from roads and

provide Delhi with a modern, secure, and energy-efficient lighting network," the Chief Minister said during the meeting.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh and senior officials from multiple departments attended the meeting where the proposal was cleared. The initiative was first announced in the Delhi government's 2026-27 Budget.

According to officials, Delhi currently has around 45,000 conventional HPSV street lights and nearly 51,000 older LED lights installed on PWD roads. The network also includes more than 51,000



poles. Under the new project, all existing fixtures will be replaced with smart LED lights.

The Government will also install 5,000 additional poles to improve lighting in uncovered and poorly lit stretches.

One of the key features of the project is the establishment of a centralised Command and Control

Centre that will monitor every street light in real time. The system will immediately detect faults and allow remote operation of lights.

Officials said the smart system would also allow lighting intensity to be adjusted according to requirements. The brightness can reportedly be increased or reduced by up to 90 per cent, helping improve energy efficiency and operational control.

Government officials believe the project will help address complaints related to faulty street lights, which often remained unresolved for long periods under the existing system because

authorities relied mainly on public complaints to identify breakdowns.

The Chief Minister said the modern lighting system would improve visibility on roads and contribute to reducing accidents. She added that better-lit roads would also improve women's safety in several areas of the city where dark stretches remain a concern.

The government estimates that the project will lead to major savings in electricity costs. Once fully implemented, the smart LED network is expected to save nearly ₹25 crore annually in power expenses. Officials said the

savings over the next five years would be substantial compared to the current lighting arrangement, which consumes more electricity and requires higher maintenance. The project is also expected to reduce light pollution by introducing standardised fixtures and advanced lighting controls across the city.

During the meeting, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh suggested that the project should be given a special name due to its scale and importance. The proposal was accepted by the Chief Minister, though the name has not yet been announced.

Capital under heatwave grip for second consecutive day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An intense spell of heat gripped the national capital on Wednesday as Delhi recorded a heatwave for the second consecutive day, with temperatures hovering around the 45 degrees Celsius mark and the weather office maintaining an orange alert for the coming days amid forecasts of prolonged heatwave conditions.

Earlier, the national capital region experienced a warm Wednesday morning as the minimum temperature settled at 28.3 degrees Celsius, which is almost two notches above the normal, leading to discomfort at night.

Wednesday also marked the fifth heatwave recorded in Delhi this year. Heatwave conditions were earlier recorded on April 23, 24, 25 and May 19, according to an official of the weather department.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), heatwave conditions were witnessed in isolated places, with Safdarjung, the city's base weather monitor-



People cover themselves on a hot summer day in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

ing station, recording a maximum temperature of 44.5 degrees Celsius, 4.1 notches above normal, while 0.6 degree lower than the previous day. The Palam station also logged 44.9 degrees Celsius, 3.6 notches above normal with a 24-hour decline of 0.2 degree.

The Lodhi Road station recorded a maximum temperature of 44.6 degrees Celsius, 5.6 notches above normal and 0.6 degree lower than the previous day, while the Ridge station recorded the hottest temperature in the

city at 45.8 degrees Celsius, 4.3 notches above normal with a 24-hour decline of 0.7 degree. Ayanagar station recorded a maximum temperature of 45 degrees Celsius, 2.9 notches above normal and 0.5 degree lower than the previous day.

The minimum temperature settled at 28.3 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 1.8 notches above normal and 0.1 degrees higher than the previous day, while Palam recorded 28.5 degrees Celsius, 1.4 notches above normal with a 24-hour rise of 0.4 degree.

DELHI'S POWER DEMAND PAST 8000 MW

New Delhi: Unrelenting heat in the national capital on Wednesday pushed the power demand to 8,039MW, the highest ever this year. Given the forecast for a continuing heatwave for the next few days, the peak hour power demand may cross 9,000 MW. The power distribution companies (discoms) successfully met the surge in their respective areas on Wednesday.

Delhi's peak power demand has seen a sharp rise in May 2026 compared to previous years, reflecting the impact of an intense and early summer. According to SLDC data, peak power demand on Wednesday touched 8039 MW at 3:35 pm. On Tuesday, peak power demand had reached 7,776 MW in the afternoon and further increased to 7,841 MW during the night.

In comparison, the peak demand till May 20 stood at 7,533 MW in 2025 and 7,591 MW in 2024. Between May 1 and May 20, Delhi's peak power demand in 2026 was higher than the

corresponding day of 2025 on 15 out of 20 days – 75% of the days. Compared to 2024, Delhi's peak demand in 2026 was higher on 13 out of 20 days – 65% of the days. BSES discoms are fully geared up to ensure reliable power supply to more than 53 lakh consumers and nearly 2.25 crore residents across South, West, East and Central Delhi.

These arrangements include long-term PPAs, bilateral tie-ups, banking arrangements with other states and deployment of advanced technologies such as AI and ML-based demand forecasting to accurately estimate load and maintain uninterrupted supply. BSES discoms have been successfully meeting Delhi's rising power demand.

Given the increasing impact of weather volatility on electricity demand, BSES has also adopted a phased power procurement strategy to optimise costs while ensuring adequate availability of power during the summer months.

Hospitals witness surge in patients suffering from heat-related illnesses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As the capital swelters under intense heat, city hospitals are witnessing a surge in patients suffering from dehydration, exhaustion, dizziness and other heat-related illnesses, with doctors warning that rapidly fluctuating temperatures may leave people vulnerable to both heat stress and seasonal infections.

Delhi recorded the first heatwave day of the month on Tuesday, with dry winds and the searing sun pushing temperatures past 45 degrees Celsius. The weather office has issued an alert for moderate to severe heatwave conditions over the next few days.

The impact of the soaring temperatures is becoming visible in OPDs and emergency wards across city hospitals, with labourers exposed to the harsh afternoon sun reporting heat stress, while elderly persons arrive with weakness and dehydration.



A man splashes water on his face to beat the heat on a hot summer day, in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

Doctors said complaints linked to heat exhaustion, heat cramps, dehydration, lethargy and electrolyte imbalance have increased sharply over the past few weeks amid above-normal maximum temperatures.

Dr Arvind Kumar Agarwal, Director, Internal Medicine at Sri Balaji Action Medical Institute said emergency units are witnessing a sharp rise in patients exhibiting symptoms of dehydration, heat exhaustion and early signs of heat stroke.

According to him, hospitals are currently witnessing around 15-25 heat-related cases daily, with emergency departments handling three to four cases requiring urgent medical attention.

Agarwal said some patients required hospitalisation, particularly those showing signs of altered cognition, high body temperature and electrolyte imbalance, warning that delayed treatment could affect the brain, kidneys and cardiovascular system.

Delhi Metro refutes any chaos, puts in best measures to handle commuters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With footfall increasing in the Delhi Metro, appropriate arrangements have been put in place to manage passenger movement, and services continued across the network in a safe and controlled manner.

On reports of chaos at some of the stations, Delhi Metro said while temporary crowding at major interchange stations during peak periods is not uncommon in a high-capacity urban transit system, isolated commuter experiences or temporary crowding at interchange stations during peak hours cannot be construed as evidence of systemic planning failure.

"Delhi Metro continuously monitors passenger movement and manages train operations across the network, including extra stoppage time at interchange stations which witness high passenger movement. Passenger demand variations, particularly during peak hours and at interchange stations, are



addressed through established operational protocols, including service regulation, crowd management measures and continuous monitoring. It is also noteworthy to mention that against the average weekdays passenger journeys of 65-70 lakh reported, 19th May recorded approx. 67.65 lakh passenger journeys, indicating no unusual surge," DMRC said in a statement to *The Pioneer*.

DMRC urged that news reports pertaining to the commuters' services should be presented in a balanced way based on verified operational facts after cross-checking from the official spokesperson of DMRC. Responsible reporting based on verified facts is essential to avoid unnecessary public apprehension and misinformation, DMRC added.

Delhi speeds up landfill cleanup, reclaims 75 acres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi has processed more than 255 lakh metric tonnes of legacy waste from its three major landfill sites and reclaimed nearly 75 acres of land, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood said on Wednesday while presenting the capital's waste remediation progress at the national Swachh Bharat Mission review conference in Vigyan Bhavan.

The review meeting was chaired by Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal Khattar and attended by representatives from states and urban local bodies across the country. Presenting Delhi's progress, Sood said the city has witnessed a sharp rise in landfill remediation work after the current government took charge under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

According to the figures shared at the conference, around 255.03 lakh metric tonnes of legacy waste have been biominer from the Okhla, Bhalswa, and Ghaziipur landfill sites so far. The minister said the pace of waste processing has increased significantly



cantly over the last few years. In 2022-23, only 21.9 lakh metric tonnes of waste were processed during the entire year. In comparison, Delhi processed 74.11 lakh metric tonnes during 2025-26 alone.

Officials said daily waste processing capacity has also expanded rapidly. The city was processing nearly 6,000 metric tonnes of waste per day in 2022-23. That figure has now increased to around 20,000 metric tonnes per day.

To support the operation, the number of trommel machines deployed across landfill sites has increased to 70. Officials said all machines are operating in double shifts to accelerate waste clearance.

Sood told the conference that nearly an 82 per cent reduction in legacy waste has already been achieved at both the Okhla and Bhalswa landfill sites.

Melody toffees sold out on Amazon, Blinkit after viral Modi-Meloni diplomatic moment

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

By the time Parle Products vice president Mayank Shah woke up on Wednesday, Melody toffees had sold out on Amazon and Blinkit. The stock market was surging. His phone rang nonstop.

Overnight, the brand he markets had gained a global audience of hundreds of millions, thanks to a small packet of candy at a diplomatic dinner in Rome. "We did not expect anything remotely like this," Shah told a news agency, calling it an "internet-breaking moment."

He said the company expects increased domestic and international sales after

the viral clip of Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifting Melody toffees to Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni in Rome. The modest gift triggered events across social media, quick commerce platforms, and the stock market.

On Blinkit and Amazon, Melody toffees sold out within hours of the video going viral. Inspired by a world leader receiving the candy as a diplomatic gesture, consumers ordered faster than warehouses could keep up. For a toffee that sells for a few rupees, it was an unusual morning.

Shah said Parle exports Melody to over 100 countries. But the attention from one video during a bilateral



meeting is not something marketing budgets can replicate. "Moments like these give Indian brands a global spotlight that no advertisement can buy," he said, thanking the Prime Minister for choosing an Indian product as a world-stage gift.

The out-of-stock notices on Amazon and Blinkit told their own story. Throughout

the day, consumers searching for Melody toffees on quick-commerce platforms encountered out-of-stock notices.

The demand spike was so rapid that it exhausted existing inventory before replenishment could occur, a problem most confectionery brands would consider a welcome one.

The viral moment also produced an unintended chapter in the stock markets. Some retail investors appeared to mistake Parle Products for another unrelated company with a similar name, leading to unusual trading activity despite their lack of connection. The company is focused on making the most of the attention while it lasts.



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IN FOCUS



An Indian pond heron perches on a wooden log in a water body as it looks for a prey in Nadia, West Bengal on Wednesday

PTI

Ladakh admin grants industry status to hospitality sector



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Leh/Jammu

The Lieutenant Governor Administration of Ladakh has decided to grant ‘industry’ status to hotels and guest houses registered with the Tourism Department, a move aimed at strengthening the region’s hospitality sector and boosting tourism-led economic growth, officials said . Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena, in a post on X, said hotels and guest houses registered with the Tourism Department in Ladakh would be accorded “industry” status, making them eligible for incentives, concessions.

India, Italy elevate ties to strategic partnership

Both countries have now set an ambitious target of achieving annual bilateral trade worth Euro 20 billion by 2029.

Italy is currently India’s fourth-largest trading partner within the European Union and has identified India as a priority nation under its global trade strategy. The Indian community in Italy has also continued to grow steadily. As of January 2025, around 186,833 Indians reside in Italy, making it one of the largest Indian diaspora communities in the European Union. More than 5,100 Indian students are currently enrolled in Italian universities.

PM calls review meet amid buzz of reshuffle

At the meeting to be chaired by the PM on Thursday, the functioning of various ministries and departments, key decisions taken in the recent past, their outcomes and future plans will be discussed, the sources said on Wednesday.

Sources said sectors like energy, agriculture, fertilisers, aviation, shipping and logistics may get focused attention at the meeting.

The prime minister had earlier outlined the reform priorities for the next 10 years, asserting that his Government’s “Reform Express” has delivered systemic transformation and benefited common citizens in a significant way.

All the probable changes will take into account the 2027 assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh and Gujarat. The party is eyeing Punjab, where it is no longer allied with the Shiromani Akali Dal and is preparing for a direct contest with the ruling AAP, as the State would see an interesting three-cornered contest with Congress in between.

Rahul’s remark against PM triggers BJP outrage

Speaking at a rally Raebareilly, honouring the legacy of local revolutionary Veera Pasi, Gandhi had accused the prime minister of “attacking the Constitution 24 hours a day” by weakening MNREGA, not conducting a caste census, and favouring select industrialists.

He pointed to the PM’s recent plea for citizens to cut back on fuel, gold, and foreign travel, warning that such appeals signal looming economic trouble. “Inflation will rise sharply in the coming months. Essentials like fuel, gas, and food grains will become costlier, squeezing purchasing power and making daily life harder,” he cautioned.

He warned that shortages of fertiliser and kerosene, vital for farms and homes, could drive

CBI books former Navy captain in disproportionate assets case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

The CBI has registered an FIR against a former Indian Navy captain for allegedly amassing disproportionate assets worth over ₹3 crore, officials said on Wednesday.

The officer, who joined the Navy as a sub-lieutenant on July 1, 1989, rose to the rank of captain — equivalent to a colonel in the Army — on August 6, 2016, before retiring in 2024, they said.

During his service as captain, he held several sensitive postings, including at the Directorate of Network Centric Operations, HQ SFC (Strategic Forces Command); Naval Dockyard, Mumbai; Directorate of Quality Assurance (Naval) Cell in BHEL; National Security Council Secretariat & Directorate of Naval Design (Submarine



Design Group), they said.

According to the FIR, the officer was allegedly involved in corrupt practices and acquired substantial immovable assets disproportionate to his known sources of income.

The agency alleged that the officer acquired several assets between 2010 and 2020 — a period covering much of his tenure as commander and captain in the Navy. During the period, the family’s assets allegedly

increased from ₹2.31 crore to ₹6.90 crore, with immovable properties nearly doubling in numbers, they said.

After taking into account the income and expenditure of the accused officer and his family members including his wife and two sons the CBI alleged that assets worth ₹3.18 could not be satisfactorily explained, leading to the registration of a case under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

“The suspect officer had

reportedly constructed a farmhouse on land purchased by him in Panchkula in 2011. The expenditure incurred on the construction of the said farmhouse and its maintenance has not been considered.

“Movable assets, including vehicles, which were reportedly acquired during the check period, are also not considered,” the FIR alleged.

It said expenses incurred on the education of the officer’s children had not yet been factored into the calculation. “As such, the amount of disproportionate assets is likely to increase during the investigation once these expenditures are also considered. Moreover, the properties acquired are situated in posh areas, and he and his family members have reportedly led a lavish and extravagant lifestyle,” the FIR alleged.

Telangana CM orders special cell to boost investments

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Wednesday directed officials to initiate land acquisition for the proposed high-speed rail corridor on the city outskirts and set up a dedicated investment promotion cell to be named ‘Invest Telangana’.

At a meeting with Industries Minister D Sridhar Babu and senior officials, Reddy called for the establishment of a special office for ‘Invest Telangana’ and preparing a logo and website for it, an official release said. He instructed officials to



introduce an ‘escort officer’ system to facilitate investors and study the industrial policies of Tamil Nadu and Gujarat. Reddy ordered steps

to be taken to establish a ‘Data City’ in 1,500 acres and identify Government lands nearby for setting up Global Capability Centres (GCC) and

Data Centres. He asked officials to make efforts to see that GCCs are set up in Tier-2 cities.

The CM also called for efforts to attract a ‘health cluster’ of Centre to the ‘Bharat Future City’ being developed on the outskirts of Hyderabad by the State Government. Stressing the need for world-class infrastructure in the Future City, he suggested studying the models of reputed world cities.

The Future City should emerge as a home to an international organisation, he added. Reddy sought laying the foundation stone for an industrial park in the Future

City in June and directed land allotments after the development of infrastructure.

The Government would allot 500 acres to public representatives, civil service officers and journalists, he said.

The Railway Ministry in February said it has initiated steps to expedite the implementation of seven new High-Speed Rail (HSR) corridors announced in the Union Budget 2026. “The proposed corridors include Mumbai-Pune, Pune-Hyderabad, Hyderabad-Bengaluru, Hyderabad-Chennai, Chennai-Bengaluru, Delhi-Varanasi and Varanasi-Siliguri.

Dowry death case filed after 25-year-old woman dies in West Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

A 25-year-old woman died after allegedly falling from a building in West Delhi’s Dasghara Village area, following which the police registered a dowry death case against her husband and his two brothers, officials



said on Wednesday. According to the police, a PCR call was received on May 18 regarding a woman who had fallen from a building near Holi Chowk in Dasghara Village, under the jurisdiction of the Inderpuri police station.

A police team rushed to the spot and shifted the

injured woman to a hospital, where doctors declared her “brought dead”.

The deceased was identified as a 25-year-old woman and the wife of Raju Singh.

Police sources said both the woman’s family and her marital family were from lower-middle-class backgrounds. As the marriage had

taken place within seven years, legal proceedings related to dowry death were initiated, and the matter was reported to the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM), Karol Bagh.

Police sources also mentioned that the investigation revealed harassment about dowry by the accused.

Officials said the SDM recorded statements of the victim’s family members. At the same time, the Crime Team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) team from Rohini inspected the spot and collected evidence.

Based on the inquiry, statements and the post-mortem examination con-

ducted on Tuesday, the police registered FIR under Sections 80 (Dowry Death) and 3(5) (Common Intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) against the woman’s husband, Raju Singh, and his two brothers. Police said further investigation into the case is underway.

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promised to fight. If the CBI and MHA act without fear or bias, this could be the start of a much-needed clean-up. If not, the next Subhash Yadav is already being paid off.

Twisha death probe deepens

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said the State Government will seek a CBI probe into Sharma’s death.

Advocate Ankur Pandey, representing Twisha’s family, said the plea seeking a fresh autopsy and preservation of the body was only partly accepted by the court. While the request for a second post-mortem was rejected, the court instructed authorities to ensure preservation of the body for further legal proceedings if required.

Twisha, a resident of Noida, was found hanging under suspicious circumstances at her matrimonial home in Bhopal’s Katara Hills area on May 12, barely five months after her marriage to advocate Samarth Singh in December 2025. Her death has triggered widespread outrage and allegations of dowry harassment, mental torture and destruction of evidence.

The initial post-mortem was conducted at AIIMS Bhopal. However, Twisha’s family alleged serious irregularities in the procedure and demanded a fresh autopsy by an independent medical board. In their plea before the court, the family claimed that the ligature material allegedly used in the hanging was not provided during the post-mortem examination and questioned delays in registration of the FIR.

Twisha’s father, Navnidhi Sharma, accused investigators of tampering with evidence and mishandling the probe. “Without even submitting the ligature, the post-mortem report was released. In such a system, how can a middle-class person expect justice?” he alleged.

Police have registered a case against Twisha’s husband Samarth Singh and mother-in-law Giribala Singh under charges related to dowry death and harassment. A Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been constituted to investigate allegations of dowry harassment, assault and destruction of evidence.

Meanwhile, Samarth Singh remains untraceable, prompting police to intensify search operations. Earlier, a Bhopal court had rejected his anticipatory bail plea, observing that the allegations were serious and that the death had occurred within months of marriage under suspicious circumstances. The Bhopal police Commissioner has announced a reward of Rs 30,000 on the arrest of Samarth.

According to investigators, Twisha had allegedly sent distress messages and made emotional phone calls to her family shortly before her death. Family members claimed she was under severe mental stress and had repeatedly expressed a desire to leave her matrimonial home.

After Twisha’s family met Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav seeking an impartial investigation, official sources, said the Madhya Pradesh Government is likely to write to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) recommending a probe into the case. Sources also indicated that the state Government may facilitate transportation of the body to AIIMS Delhi if requested by the family.

Amid the growing controversy, Bhopal police urged the family to take custody of the body, citing concerns over decomposition. In a communication to the family, police stated that AIIMS Bhopal was currently preserving the body at minus four degrees Celsius, while doctors had advised that long-term preservation required storage at minus 80 degrees Celsius - a facility not available at the hospital.

Twisha Sharma had earlier worked as an actress and model and had appeared in Telugu films and advertisements before pursuing higher studies and later getting married. Her death has sparked fresh debate over alleged harassment faced by women in matrimonial homes and the handling of dowry-related investigations.

Heatwave triggers spike in vehicle fire incidents...

A Delhi Fire Services official explained the underlying mechanics, “Heat is not the only factor, but it is certainly a major one. As temperatures rise, the load on the electrical infrastructure increases significantly. Air conditioners run continuously, wiring heats up, and transformers operate under stress, which raises the chances of short circuits and fire incidents.”

A cab driver in the Capital he had started keeping the bonnet open during long breaks between rides. “If I keep the engine running with the AC on for more than an hour in a traffic jam, the temperature gauge goes to the red,” he said. “I have seen two cars catch fire this month near Ashram Chowk. Both times the car was stuck in traffic.” He said he now carries a small fire extinguisher in his vehicle, something he never thought necessary before this summer.

Similarly, a mechanic who has been servicing cars for nearly two decades said May 2026 has been his busiest month ever. “I am seeing overheating complaints every single day. People come in with coolant problems, radiator failures, and wiring issues. The heat outside means the engine has to work much harder just to maintain a normal temperature. If there is any existing weakness in the system, this weather finds it,” he said.

A used car dealer said he had started adding a caution about summer maintenance to every vehicle he sold. “Earlier, it was only something you told buyers of old cars. Now I am telling everyone. Even relatively new vehicles are at risk if the coolant levels are not checked, if the wiring has

any wear, or if the AC compressor is running under full load for hours.”

The DFS has been attending around 120 calls a day in April, compared to about 70 to 80 calls in preceding months. Fire-related emergencies surged by 73 percent in April compared to March, with 32 people losing their lives in fire accidents between January and April this year.

The IMD, in its heatwave advisory, has specifically told vehicle owners to keep fire extinguishers in their cars and to regularly check wiring, engine temperature, and fuel systems during peak summer. Experts warn that extreme summer temperatures increase the risk of vehicle fires, particularly when engines overheat or electrical systems malfunction, and that continuous exposure to scorching heat, long driving hours, fuel leakage, poor maintenance, or short circuits can trigger such incidents.

Govt acts on NEET rumours

Officials said Pradhan directed strict action against fake Telegram channels spreading misinformation related to the medical-entrance exam.

The minister stressed the need for heightened vigilance and foolproof security arrangements to ensure the safe, secure and fair conduct of NEET-UG, according to officials.

Senior officials from the Ministry of Education and the director general of the National Testing Agency (NTA) were also present at the meeting, where preparations were reviewed in detail to identify vulnerabilities in advance and ensure timely preventive and corrective measures.

“It was highlighted that many such links redirect users to automated bots and fake groups designed to amplify misinformation,” an official said. According to inputs shared by intelligence agencies, multiple suspicious channels are being operated through a limited set of phone numbers, indicating coordinated and organised activity. Taking strong note of the issue, Pradhan directed a focussed crackdown on such networks, including proactive identification, blocking and takedown of channels spreading fake information and propaganda before examinations.

The minister said social-media platforms must work in close coordination with the Ministry of Education, the NTA and law-enforcement agencies to curb misinformation swiftly and protect the integrity of the examination system. He reiterated that safeguarding students from misleading narratives and maintaining public confidence in the examination process is a top priority for the Government. The NEET (UG) 2026 for admissions in undergraduate medical courses held on May 3 was cancelled by the NTA recently amid allegations of paper leak. The matter is being probed by the CBI, while the re-test is scheduled to be held on June 21.



Punjab CM announces free bus rides for NEET aspirants

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Chandigarh

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday said the State Government has decided to waive the fare for all students travelling in Punjab Roadways buses to reach their respective centres for the NEET UG re-examination to be held on June 21.

“Many poor students take the NEET exam. They don’t even have the money to pay for the fare to get to the exam centre.

“When (Arvind) Kejriwal spoke to the NEET students recently, they requested help... Therefore, the Punjab Government has decided to waive the fare for all students taking the NEET exam in all Punjab Roadways buses on June 20, 21 and 22. Show your admit card, and you won’t be charged a ticket,” Mann said in a post on X in Punjabi.

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) held on May 3 was cancelled following allegations of irregularities in the examination process.

Following complaints from NEET aspirants about financial difficulties and

mental stress after the exam was cancelled, AAP national convener Kejriwal on Tuesday said he would request Punjab Chief Minister Mann to make bus travel free for the candidates in the State on the day of re-examination.

In a video on X, Kejriwal said many students had reached out to him after he sought feedback and suggestions regarding the NEET examination issue.

He said that over 50 lakh people had watched his earlier video and thousands of students had shared their concerns, including anxiety, depression and frustration over the cancellation of the examination and the rescheduling of the test for June 21. Addressing concerns raised by students about travel expenses, Kejriwal said he would speak to Mann regarding free bus travel for NEET aspirants in the state on the examination day.

“Some children have written that they do not have enough money to afford bus fare. I am going to Punjab tomorrow and will speak to Bhagwant Mann so that at least in Punjab, bus travel can be made free for students on the day of the examination,” he said.

Administrative delay deprives people of rights, says President

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Asserting that refraining from making a decision does not constitute morality, President Droupadi Murmu on Wednesday said a delay in administrative decision-making is tantamount to depriving people of their legitimate interests.

Addressing Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officers of the 2024 batch, who had called on the President at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, Murmu said that ethics and governance are the two sides of the same coin.

“You have to be honest and ethical. At the same time, you have to deliver results. IAS officers are expected to exercise the powers delegated to them,” she said.

The President said that refraining from making a decision does not constitute morality.

“Rather, making the right decisions in alignment with



the public interest and established order represents the true essence of morality. Just as a delay in the delivery of justice is deemed a denial of justice, so too is a delay in administrative decision-making tantamount to depriving people of their legitimate interests,” Murmu said.

Quoting former Deputy Prime Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, she said some remnants of pre-independence practices and

behaviour patterns still survive in certain areas of governance. “Such practices must be eradicated. You have to contribute to this national objective,” the President said.

Addressing IAS probationers in 1947, Patel had said: “It will be your bounden duty to treat the common men in India as your own, or to put it correctly, to feel yourself to be one of them and amongst them.”

“This statement becomes

especially relevant in the context of our ongoing national efforts for mental decolonisation,” Murmu said.

The President told officers that accepting the status quo may often be the most convenient option, but not necessarily the best option.

“Recognising when things need to change and having the conviction, ability and courage to see it through is the marker of an effective civil servant,” she stated.

The President stated that no effort is required to simply drift along with the flowing current.

To achieve the goal of a ‘Viksit Bharat’ and to elevate our society to the pinnacle of progress, officers will often have to move forward by striving against the tide, Murmu said, and advised them to keep the people of India, particularly the marginalised sections of society, at the very centre of their thoughts and actions, whether they are out in the field or working in the office.

J&K: 3.39 lakh new voters added in Panchayat electoral rolls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The State Election Commission, Jammu & Kashmir, has added a total of 3,39,384 new voters to the Panchayat electoral rolls, while 1,13,344 names were deleted due to death, shifting, duplication, and other admissible reasons during the current revision.

The final roll now stands at 72,24,131 electors, which includes 36,62,502 male, 35,61,488 female, and 141 Third gender voters.

This marks a net increase of 2,26,040 voters compared to the previous revision concluded in January 2025, when the rolls listed 69,98,091 voters with January 1, 2025, as the qualifying date.

The comprehensive exercise, which began with the release of the Draft Electoral Roll on March 27, 2026, has now formally culminated following a structured schedule of claims, objections and verification.

The Commission had opened a 40-day window for filing claims and objections from March 27 to May 5, 2026. All submissions received during this period were examined and disposed of by Electoral Registration Officers by May



14, 2026. With the completion of this process, the Final Electoral Rolls were published today, May 21, 2026, setting the groundwork for the upcoming panchayat elections across the Union Territory.

The revision drive recorded significant voter activity. A total of 3,39,384 new voters were added to the rolls while 1,13,344 names were deleted due to death, shifting, duplication, and other admissible reasons. In addition, corrections were carried out in the particulars of 17,664 voters, and 31,590 voters were transposed. The Commission said the exercise witnessed substantial participation from the eligible citizens, with 5,10,285 forms received during the revision period. These forms were processed by Panchayat Election Booth Officials, Assistant Electoral

Registration Officers, and Electoral Registration Officers in accordance with the procedure and timelines prescribed by the Commission.

To maximise outreach, the SEC undertook extensive SVEEP campaigns through print and electronic media, including radio jingles, voter appeals by the State Election Commissioner and regular newspaper advertisements.

State Election Commissioner Shantmanu commended the coordinated efforts of District Panchayat Election Officers, EROs, AEROS, PEBOS, the staff of the State Election Commission and the Rural Development & Panchayati Raj Department, as well as representatives of political parties. He also thanked the public for their active participation and cooperation in the successful completion of the revision exercise.

India, South Korea review defence ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and South Korea on Wednesday reviewed the entire spectrum of their bilateral defence ties during talks between Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and his counterpart Ahn Gyu-back in Seoul.

Agreements were also exchanged on promoting cooperation in the field of Defence Cyber; training between India's National Defence College and Korea National Defence University; and UN Peacekeeping Cooperation, making the partnership stronger and multidimensional, the defence ministry said.

The two Ministers discussed ways to



further expand collaboration in areas such as industry, production, maritime security, emerging technologies, military exchanges, logistics and regional security.

Congress to join TN Cabinet after 59 years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Congress will be part of the Tamil Nadu Cabinet after a gap of 59 years as two of its MLAs, Rajesh Kumar and P Vishwanathan, will take oath as ministers on Thursday, the party said



Rajesh Kumar, P Vishwanathan

on Wednesday.

Announcing the decision, AICC general secretary, organisation, KC Venugopal said, “INC President Mallikarjun Kharge ji has approved the induction of INC MLAs Adv. Rajesh Kumar and Thiru P Vishwanathan

into the Tamil Nadu cabinet led by CM Thiru Vijay, and they will be taking oath as Ministers tomorrow.”

“This is a historic occasion for us, as the Congress joins the Tamil Nadu Cabinet after a long gap of 59 years!” he said in a post on X.

“I convey my best wishes

to them. We are confident that they will deliver on the hopes and aspirations of the people of Tamil Nadu, and will work to realise the bold vision of welfare and pro-people governance laid down by LOP Sh Rahul Gandhi ji,” Venugopal said.

States Focus



CYPRUS PRESIDENT BEGINS 3-DAY VISIT TO INDIA

Cyprus President Nikos Christodoulides kickstarted a three-day visit to India on Wednesday to boost bilateral cooperation in areas of trade, investment, defence and technology. Christodoulides, accompanied by a high-level delegation comprising senior ministers, officials and business leaders, began his trip from Mumbai and will arrive in New Delhi on Thursday. PM Modi visited Cyprus last June. It was the first visit by an Indian prime minister to Cyprus in over two decades. The two leaders are scheduled to hold wide-ranging talks on Friday. PM Modi and President Christodoulides will hold discussions on further strengthening bilateral cooperation.



BJP MP MEDHA KULKARNI TO HEAD PAR PANEL ON SCIENCE

Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan has nominated BJP member Medha Vishram Kulkarni as chairperson of the department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Science and Technology, Environment, Forests and Climate Change. Kulkarni's appointment took place on May 18, a notification from the Rajya Sabha Secretariat said. The committee scrutinises Government policies, reviews budgetary allocations and evaluates legislation for key scientific and environmental departments. Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla has also appointed BJP member Sudheer Gupta as Chairperson of the Joint Committee on Corporate Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

CBI arrests Army Colonel in ₹50 lakh bribery case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

Colonel Himanshu Bali of the Indian Army's Army Ordnance Corps (AOC), Eastern Command, Fort William, Kolkata, has been arrested by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in connection with an alleged ₹50 lakh bribery scandal involving the manipulation of procurement tenders, approval of substandard samples, and clearance of inflated bills for a Kanpur-based private defence supplier.

The case highlights alleged deep-rooted irregularities in defence procurement under the Eastern Command. This command supplies weapons, ammunition, and ordnance



to the eastern sector forces. Colonel Bali was taken into custody in Kolkata on Tuesday (May 19/20, 2026). He was brought to Delhi for further interrogation. A Delhi court remanded him to CBI custody till May 25.

The CBI's FIR, registered on or around May 18, 2026, references the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988 (Sections

7, 8, 9, and 10, as amended in 2018) and sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for criminal conspiracy.

The FIR alleges that Colonel Bali colluded with private contractors. He allegedly manipulated the competitive bidding process to award tenders to a specific firm. He also approved substandard material and cleared pending

and inflated bills. These actions could result in financial losses to the exchequer. The beneficiary is M/S Eastern Global Limited (Eastern Global Ltd.), a Kanpur-based defence supplier. The company and its proprietors are accused of bribing to win tenders from the Eastern Command. The FIR states that the firm has supplied various defence establishments across India for a long time.

The CBI investigation began after receiving information from a source. Investigators traced events from March to April 2026. In March, regular communications took place between Colonel Bali and contractors. In April, after these interactions, a major tender was

allegedly awarded to Eastern Global Limited in return for bribes.

According to the probe, Colonel Bali and Akshat Agrawal (the firm's operator) met after hours at Park Street in Kolkata in April. This meeting happened before the tender was awarded. They allegedly finalised illicit terms for the tender at this meeting.

On April 24, 2026, just two days after the Park Street meeting, the tender was awarded to Eastern Global Limited, allegedly due to the “undue favours” extended by Colonel Bali.

Colonel Bali contacted Akshat Agrawal to demand the promised ₹50 lakh and directed that delivery be made to the Delhi-NCR.

Sustainability must remain at core of growth: Bhupender

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

As India moves steadily towards the vision of a Viksit Bharat, environmental sustainability must remain at the core of its development pathway, Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav said on Wednesday. He made the comments during his address to the participants of the mid-career training programme of the Indian Forest Service.

The minister said a forest officer's responsibility never ends, even after superannuation, as they continue to be the voice of the voiceless flora and fauna.

During the event, Yadav highlighted India's progress in climate-change mitigation, achieving NDC (Nationally Determined Contributions) targets ahead of schedule, improvements in forest and wildlife governance systems, and the use of advanced technologies for environmental management.



He also spoke about cheetah conservation, great Indian bustard conservation through artificial incubation, the role of tiger reserves in sustaining river systems and the importance of balancing conservation with development.

The event was also attended by Minister of State Kirtivardhan Singh, who noted India's leadership in global conservation diplomacy and stressed the importance of balancing development with conservation.

meeting with Helen Clark, Board Chair of the Partnership for Maternal, Newborn and Child Health (PMNCH), on the sidelines of the 79th World Health Assembly in Geneva.

The minister expressed readiness to provide technical guidance and support to other countries and invited PMNCH to showcase India's successful models and innovations through physical and virtual platforms.

Reaffirming India's commitment to advancing the global agenda for women's, children's and adolescents' health, the minister highlight-

ed India's long association with PMNCH since its inception in 2005 and said the country remains proud to continue contributing meaningfully to the organisation's objectives.

“India has been the bed of innovation and delivering interventions at scale with equity and accessibility. We have kept the health of women, children and adolescents at the heart of our service delivery and sustainable development,” Nadda said during the meeting.

Nadda underlined India's active leadership role in



PMNCH as vice chair of its board and chair of its standing committee. He also informed that India's annual

BWSSB ranks among top 5 global water utilities

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The BWSSB has emerged as one of the top five global utilities at the Global Water Summit 2026 held in Madrid, Spain, officials said on Wednesday.

The Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board has “made history by becoming the only Indian water utility to secure a place” among the global top 5 in three major award categories, earning widespread recognition for Bengaluru's innovative and sustainable water management practices, they said.

The Global Water Summit 2026 took place from May 18 to May 20 in Madrid.



According to a statement, BWSSB's integrated approach to water conservation, wastewater recycling, reuse, and sustainable urban water governance-popularly referred to as its “five pillars” strategy-received significant international attention at the summit.

The board was recognised for its contribution towards

achieving United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 6 (SDG-6), which focuses on ensuring clean water and sanitation for all.

In this category, BWSSB featured alongside globally reputed utilities including Aguas Nuevas (Chile), Indah Water Konsortium (Malaysia), SANASA (Brazil), and Sanepar of Parana (Brazil). BWSSB

was also listed among the top five globally in the prestigious “utility of the year” category, one of the highest recognitions in the international water sector. The recognition was based on the board's performance over the past three years in areas including urban water supply, sanitation management, technology adoption, infrastructure expansion, and sustainable utility governance, it said.

BWSSB's flagship Cauvery Stage V Drinking Water Project, implemented to address Bengaluru's growing water demand, also secured a place among the top five global projects in the “water project of the year” category, the board said.

India ready to provide technical guidance, support in maternal, child healthcare: Nadda

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has been “the bed of innovation” in delivering large-scale healthcare interventions with equity and has much to offer the global community through evidence-based best practices, Union Health Minister JP Nadda said on Wednesday.

He stressed that the country has kept women, children and adolescents at the centre of its service delivery and sustainable development goals. Nadda made the remarks during a bilateral

Highlighting India's public health achievements, Nadda said the country was among the first to launch a dedicated national programme for adolescents in 2014, reaching young people through facility-based, school-based and community-based interventions across the country.

Referring to progress in maternal and child health indicators, Nadda said India has recorded significant reductions in Maternal Mortality Ratio (MMR) and Infant Mortality Rate (IMR) at a pace surpassing global trends.

The minister said India has much to offer the global community through evidence-based best practices and successful large-scale public health interventions.

Reiterating India's commitment as PMNCH vice chair, Nadda conveyed the country's willingness to support the organisation across a range of priorities, including women's, children's and adolescents' health and the growing burden of non-communicable diseases.

He also noted that India has developed substantial technical resources and digital

public health goods that could be shared globally for wider benefit.

Invoking the ancient Indian philosophy of “*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*” or “the world is one family”, the minister emphasised India's belief in unity, compassion and shared humanity in addressing global health challenges.

Clark appreciated India's continued leadership and contributions to global public health and acknowledged the country's important role within PMNCH and the broader global health architecture.

Suvendu hands over land to BSF for border fencing in West Bengal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Wednesday handed over land to the BSF for international boundary fencing and security infrastructure, beginning with a 27 km stretch, and said more land would be provided wherever required to strengthen border management in the State.

Addressing a BSF land transfer meeting, Adhikari said the process marked the beginning of a larger initiative to improve border security in the State.

“The land will be handed over to the Border Security Force (BSF) within two weeks. Initially, land covering a 27 km stretch along the India-Bangladesh international boundary is being handed over,” he said.

Calling it the first step in a broader exercise, Adhikari said, “As a beginning, the land required to secure the 27 km stretch is being provided to the BSF.” Highlighting the need to expedite border infrastructure, the chief minister said a sizeable portion of West Bengal’s international boundary still remained unfenced. “In West Bengal, around 1,600 km of the total 2,200 km border with Bangladesh has already been fenced, while nearly 600 km still remains unfenced,” he said.

“Wherever land is needed for fencing and border security, we will hand it over to the BSF,” he added.

Targeting the previous Trinamool Congress Government, Adhikari alleged that it had failed to cooperate on border infrastructure because of “vote bank pol-



itics and appeasement policies”.

“The previous Government, due to its vote bank politics and appeasement policies, did not give land to the BSF,” he claimed.

Adhikari also alleged that coordination among the BSF, state police and district administration in bordering areas had weakened over the years. “For the last several years, coordination meetings between the BSF, state police and administration in bordering areas had not happened,” he said. He said the district-level coordination mechanism had now been revived. “The district coordination meetings have now started, and these will happen regularly now,” the chief minister said. Announcing a stricter

policy on illegal immigration, Adhikari said the State has implemented a provision for the handover of the infiltrators nabbed by the police to the BSF.

“A letter was sent by the Centre to the state last year regarding the direct handover of infiltrators to the BSF, but the previous Government failed to implement this important provision. We have now enforced it,” he said.

Adhikari said those not covered under the Citizenship (Amendment) Act would be treated as infiltrators and action would be taken accordingly.

“Those who are not covered under the CAA will be treated as infiltrators.

The state police will arrest them and hand them over to the BSF,” he said.

Kerala CM Satheesan to handle Finance and Law portfolios

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Chief Minister VD Satheesan will handle the key Finance and Law portfolios, along with 36 other departments, after Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar on Wednesday allocated portfolios among the UDF Cabinet ministers in Kerala who were sworn in on May 18.

Following the Chief Minister’s recommendations, which the Governor approved, senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala was designated Minister for Home, Vigilance and three other departments.

The portfolios were later circulated via a gazette notification, as per which the CM will also handle all important policy matters and subjects not mentioned elsewhere.

Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leader PK Kunhalikutty will take care of Industries and Commerce, Information Technology, Artificial Intelligence, Startups,

Mining and Geology and Handlooms and Textiles, it said.



Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan addresses a press conference after a cabinet meeting in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday

Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) chief Sunny Joseph was given charge of Electricity, Environment and Parliamentary Affairs, while senior party leader K Muralaheedharan will head 8 departments, including Health, Devaswoms, Food Safety, Drugs Control and Medical Education, the Lok Bhavan said.

Besides them, Roji M John will handle Higher Education, AP Anil Kumar will head Land and Revenue, and N Shamsudheen will be the General Education Minister, it said.

Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) MLA Shibu Baby John got Forests and Wildlife Protection and Skill Development, while Kerala Congress (Joseph) legislator

Mon Joseph will head the Irrigation, Ground Water, Water Supply and Sanitation and Housing Departments, the Lok Bhavan added.

The Road and Water Transport Departments will be headed by Communist Marxist Party (CMPKSC) MLA CP John, Food and Civil Supplies will be taken care of by Kerala Congress (Jacob) MLA Anoop Jacob, and IUML MLA VE Abdul Gafoor will take charge of the Fisheries Department, it said.

Of the remaining IUML MLAs in the Cabinet, PK Basheer will head the Public Works Department, and KM Shaji will take charge of the Local Self Government authorities, as per the Lok Bhavan.

MEDICAL STORES SHUT ACROSS GUJARAT; STRIKE AGAINST E-PHARMACIES

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

Medical stores across Gujarat remained closed on Tuesday as chemists and druggists joined a nationwide protest against online medicine sales and the growing presence of e-pharmacy platforms. The strike, led by the All India Organisation of Chemists and Druggists (AIOCD), affected pharmacy operations in major cities including



Ahmedabad, Surat, Rajkot and Vadodara.

In Surat alone, nearly 7,000 medical stores remained shut as local chemist associations extended support to the agitation. The closure caused inconvenience to patients and residents, particularly those dependent on daily medication for chronic illnesses such as diabetes, blood pressure and other long-term health conditions.

EMBASSY				
Equinox India Infraestate Limited				
(formerly Indiabulls Infraestate Limited)				
(CIN: U70102DL2007PLC157384)				
Extract of Statement of Audited Consolidated Financial Results for the year ended 31 March 2026				
(₹ in million)				
Sl. No.	Particulars	Current year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Previous year ended 31 March 2025 (Unaudited)	
1	Total Income from Operations	584.97	629.20	
2	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(642.78)	(1,261.41)	
3	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(889.84)	(2,168.26)	
4	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(889.40)	(2,172.89)	
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(909.80)	(2,173.47)	
6	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face value Per Share ₹ 10 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(3,910.48) (3,910.48)	(9,553.68) (9,553.68)	
7	Paid up Equity Share Capital	2.27	2.27	
8	Net Worth	4,913.75	5,735.30	
9	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	4,911.48	5,733.03	
Notes to the consolidated financial results:				
1. The above consolidated results have been reviewed and approved by the Board of Directors ("the Board") at its meeting held on 20 May 2026.				
2. The Figures for the previous year ended 31 March 2025 are management certified figures which are neither subjected to audit nor reviewed by the statutory auditors of the company.				
3. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52(8), read with 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://www.embassyindia.com/EIIL) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).				
Equinox India Infraestate Limited				
(formerly Indiabulls Infraestate Limited)				
(CIN: U70102DL2007PLC157384)				
Extract of Standalone Audited Financial Results for the quarter ended 31 March 2026				
(₹ in million)				
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31 March 2026 (Unaudited)	Current year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Previous year ended 31 March 2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	139.30	584.97	629.20
2	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(313.68)	(560.93)	(1,084.50)
3	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(556.77)	(807.99)	(1,991.35)
4	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(556.33)	(807.55)	(1,997.94)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(552.04)	(827.95)	(1,998.52)
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	2.27	2.27	2.27
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	8,890.24	8,890.24	9,578.72
8	Securities Premium Account	16,123.92	16,123.92	16,123.92
9	Net Worth	8,892.51	8,892.51	9,580.99
10	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	10,955.48	10,955.48	13,973.87
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Share	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio*	1.26	1.26	1.46
13	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face value Per Share ₹ 10 each)(for continuing and discontinued operations) - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(2,746.05) (2,746.05)	(3,550.61) (3,550.61)	(8,784.37) (8,784.37)
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio*	-	-	-
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio**	-	-	-
18	Current ratio (In times)	2.15	2.15	1.23
19	Total debts to total assets	0.50	0.50	0.55
20	Long term debt to working capital (In times)#	0.68	0.68	-
21	Bad debt to account receivable ratio (In %)	-	-	-
22	Current liability ratio (In times)	0.56	0.56	1.00
23	Debtor turnover ratio (In times)	3.06	7.15	3.94
24	Inventory turnover ratio (In times)	0.02	0.06	0.13
25	Operating margin (In %)	(51.06)	(28.46)	(105.30)
26	Net profit margin (In %)	(339.72)	(123.19)	(201.17)
* Ratio can not be calculated due to negative earning available for debt service.				
* Ratio can not be calculated due to negative earning available for interest service coverage				
Notes to the standalone financial results:				
1. The above results have been reviewed and approved by the Board of Directors ("the Board") at its meeting held on 20 May 2026.				
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52(8), read with 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://www.embassyindia.com/EIIL) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).				
Registered Office: Office No 202, 2nd Floor, A-18 Rama House, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi- 110001.		For and on behalf of the Board of Directors		
Place : Gurugram Date : 20 May 2026		 Rupesh Gupta Whole-time director		

EMBASSY					
Lucina Land Development Limited					
(CIN: U70109DL2006PLC151260)					
Extract of Statement of Audited Consolidated Financial Results for the year ended 31 March 2026					
(₹ in million)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Current year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Previous year ended 31 March 2025 (Audited)		
1	Total Income from Operations	135.17	102.89		
2	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the year (before Tax, Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(477.68)	(226.17)		
3	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the year before Tax (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(479.97)	(1,144.90)		
4	Net Profit/ (Loss) for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/ or Extraordinary items)	(503.30)	(1,644.27)		
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(509.04)	(1,637.69)		
6	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face value Per Share ₹10 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(10,067.76) (10,067.76)	(32,884.98) (32,884.98)		
7	Paid up Equity Share Capital	0.50	0.50		
8	Net Worth	(11,220.95)	(10,771.44)		
9	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	(11,221.45)	(10,771.94)		
Notes to the consolidated financial results:					
1. The above consolidated results have been reviewed and approved by the Audit Committee and Board of Directors ('the Board') at its meeting held on 20 May 2026.					
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52(8), read with 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://www.embassyindia.com/EIIL) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).					
Lucina Land Development Limited					
(CIN: U70109DL2006PLC151260)					
Extract of Audited Standalone Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31 March 2026					
(₹ in million)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31 March 2026 (Refer note 3)	Corresponding quarter ended 31 March 2025 (Refer note 3)	Current year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Previous year ended 31 March 2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	4.37	(41.77)	27.67	99.56
2	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(322.54)	(141.04)	(557.73)	(252.76)
3	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(322.04)	(1,059.77)	(560.02)	(1,171.49)
4	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(332.72)	(1,552.31)	(570.70)	(1,664.03)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising (Loss) / Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(332.78)	(1,545.73)	(576.44)	(1,657.45)
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	0.50	0.50	0.50	0.50
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	(11,040.08)	(10,523.15)	(11,040.08)	(10,523.15)
8	Securities Premium Account	-	-	-	-
9	Net Worth	(11,039.58)	(10,522.65)	(11,039.58)	(10,522.65)
10	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	15,116.93	12,583.16	15,116.93	12,583.16
11	Outstanding redemption preference share	-	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio*	-	-	-	-
13	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face value Per Share ₹ 10 each) - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(6,437.72) (6,437.72)	(31,045.95) (31,045.95)	(11,411.12) (11,411.12)	(33,280.43) (33,280.43)
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio**	-	-	-	-
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	(0.88)	(9.58)	(1.56)	(10.59)
18	Current ratio (In times)	0.72	0.54	0.72	0.54
19	Total debts to total assets	1.03	1.11	1.03	1.11
20	Long term debt to working capital (In times)#	-	-	-	-
21	Bad debt to account receivable ratio (In %)	-	-	-	-
22	Current liability ratio (In times)	0.78	0.95	0.78	0.95
23	Debtor turnover ratio (In times)	0.09	-	0.57	0.85
24	Inventory turnover ratio (In times)	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.01
25	Operating margin (In %)	-	-	3.87	22.34
26	Net profit margin (In %)	(289.13)	-	(389.55)	(1,347.46)
* Ratio can not be calculated due to negative average shareholders funds.					
** Ratio can not be calculated due to negative earning available for debt service.					
# Ratio can not be calculated due to negative working capital.					
** Amount less than or equal to ₹ 5000.					
Notes to the standalone financial results:					
1. The above results have been reviewed and approved by the Audit Committee and Board of Directors ('the Board') at its meeting held on 20 May 2026.					
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52(8), read with 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://embassyindia.com/tcl/) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).					
3. Figures for the quarter ended 31 March 2026 and corresponding quarter ended 31 March 2025 represent the balancing figures between the audited figures for the full financial year and published reviewed year to date figures upto third quarter of the financial year.					
Registered Office: Office no 202, 2nd Floor,A-18 Rama House, Middle Circle, Connaught Place , New Delhi- 110 001.		For and on behalf of the Board of Directors			
Place : New Delhi Date : 20 May 2026		 Meyyappan Ramanathan Whole-time director			

Police ensured secure environment for progress in J&K: LG Manoj Sinha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday said peace is the fundamental prerequisite for development and credited the Jammu and Kashmir Police for maintaining a secure environment that enabled significant progress in the Union Territory over the past six years.

Calling for enhanced efficiency and professionalism, the Lieutenant Governor said terrorism survives on funding, networks, and support systems, which must be identified and dismantled systematically.

“Until peace is established, the dream of development cannot be fulfilled. In any part of the world where peace does not prevail, development is not possible,” he said while addressing a gathering after distributing appointment letters



to 100 newly recruited constables. Sinha said the development witnessed in Jammu and Kashmir over the past six years was the result of the efforts of successive administrations and the people, but added that the Jammu and Kashmir Police also deserved credit for maintaining peace and creating an environment conducive to development.

He said the police force has worked with a spirit of

selfless service, collective welfare, and constructive public engagement despite operating in a challenging security environment.

“The force remains on the frontline in dealing with threats of terrorism emanating from across the border,” he said. The Lieutenant Governor said security threats have evolved significantly, with terrorism now taking new and more complex forms, requiring constant vigilance and

alertness from security forces.

“Today, terrorists no longer come only with visible weapons, nor do they always appear in forms that can be easily identified. The nature of terrorism is changing and demands a new kind of alertness and constant vigilance,” he said.

He urged police personnel to remain continuously alert and cautious to ensure national security.

Sinha said officers of the Jammu and Kashmir Police have distinguished themselves through courage, commitment, and teamwork, and have carved a respected place in the history of the Union Territory as well as the nation.

“Whenever you wear the uniform of the Jammu and Kashmir Police, remember that you are carrying forward a glorious legacy and contributing to a continuing tradition of service and protection,” he said.

Karnataka LoP accuses Congress of delaying GBA elections

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Leader of Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly R Ashoka on Wednesday alleged that the Congress Government is repeatedly postponing the GBA elections out of fear of defeat, calling it a “betrayal of the people of Bengaluru.”

He said that after dividing Bengaluru into five parts, internal Congress surveys reportedly showed the party would lose in all five corporations, leading the Government to deliberately delay the elections.

He further claimed that Bengaluru in-charge Minister and Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar does not want the elections held before the transfer of power to him as CM is complete.

“Due to infighting within Congress, no decision is being taken. Heaps of garbage are piling up across Bengaluru streets, and no development work is taking place. The Congress Government is directly responsible for this situation. Since the court has once again given a final deadline, elections must be conducted within that time



frame,” Ashoka said. Speaking to reporters, he said the BJP is fully prepared for the elections, and the Government should announce the polls at the earliest.

Accusing the Congress of blaming Opposition parties after realising through internal surveys that defeat is certain in the Greater Bengaluru Authority polls, Ashoka pointed out that the BJP had earlier written to the Election Commission requesting immediate elections. “If they are confident of winning in surveys, why are they not conducting elections?” he asked.

On Wednesday, the Supreme Court extended the deadline to August 31 for holding the long-pending

elections to the five city corporations under the GBA.

On January 12, the apex court had directed the Karnataka Government and the State Election Commission to hold the polls for the Bengaluru civic body by June 30. A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi extended the deadline to August 31 and made it clear that no further extension would be granted.

The order was passed after senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the Karnataka Government, cited manpower shortages due to Census work and the upcoming Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the State.

Gujarat Govt curbs foreign trips, promotes EV use to save fuel

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gandhinagar

The Gujarat Government has announced measures, including curbs on official trips abroad and the use of technology to minimise travel, to regulate the use of fuel and foreign exchange in the wake of the West Asia crisis.

“In view of the prevailing global situation, the State Government has decided to implement measures regarding the use of petrol, diesel and foreign exchange. The instructions



issued should be followed with immediate effect,” it said in an 11-point circular issued on Tuesday.

The Government said its staff should



local trade, generating direct and indirect employment opportunities.

In another decision, the cabinet approved the Young Professionals Selection Policy-2026 for technical and specialised services in the Department of Science, Technology and Technical Education and its subordinate institutions.

“With the implementation of this policy, the Department of Science, Technology and Technical Education and its affiliated institutions will be able to ensure prompt availability of talented young professionals. Their support can also be utilised to enhance the effi-

ciency of institutions and in carrying out research and other activities”, said the Cabinet note. The Cabinet also approved the creation of a new post of Inspector General of Police (Border) under the Special Branch to strengthen border security and intelligence systems along international and inter-state borders.

Besides, the Cabinet approved continuation of the recommendations of the Fifth State Finance Commission during the financial year 2026-27, as the recommendations of the Seventh State Finance Commission are yet to be received.

Sikkim Governor promises support to highway project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gangtok

Sikkim Governor Om Prakash Mathur on Wednesday assured support for the proposed Yukuam-Legship highway via Pelling. The assurance came after Lok Sabha MP Indra Hang Subba informed the governor about the project initiated by the State Government during his visit to Gyalshing district, according to an official statement.

Tapir Constructions Limited (CIN: U70200DL2014PLC267441) EXTRACT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31 MARCH 2026					
(₹ in Millions)					
Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended 31 March 2026 (Refer note 3)	Corresponding quarter ended 31 March 2025 (Refer note 3)	Current year ended 31 March 2026 (Audited)	Previous year ended 31 March 2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	131.18	3.15	4,765.24	3.49
2	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(133.98)	(101.15)	(115.22)	(182.73)
3	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(132.64)	(101.15)	(115.86)	(182.73)
4	Net (Loss) / Profit for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(132.68)	(101.15)	(115.90)	(182.73)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising (Loss) / Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(133.07)	(97.55)	(123.54)	(179.13)
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	0.50	0.50	0.50	0.50
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	(2,351.94)	(2,268.54)	(2,351.94)	(2,268.54)
8	Securities Premium Account	-	-	-	-
9	Net Worth	(2,351.44)	(2,268.04)	(2,351.44)	(2,268.04)
10	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	4,545.31	4,438.81	4,545.51	4,438.81
11	Outstanding redemption preference share	-	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio*	-	-	-	-
13	Earnings per Share (EPS) (Face value Per Share ₹ 10 each) - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(2,652.13) (2,652.13)	(2,022.74) (2,022.74)	(2,317.25) (2,317.25)	(3,654.38) (3,654.38)
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio**	-	-	-	-
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	(1.13)	(1.09)	(0.29)	(0.66)
18	Current ratio (In times)	0.98	1.02	0.98	1.02
19	Total debts to total assets	1.43	0.73	1.43	0.73
20	Long term debt to working capital (In times)#	-	19.38	-	19.38
21	Bad debt to account receivable ratio (In %)	-	-	-	-
22	Current liability ratio (In times)	0.57	0.71	0.57	0.71
23	Debtor turnover ratio (In times)	297.20	-	10,795.89	-
24	Inventory turnover ratio (In times)	0.04	-	1.05	-
25	Operating margin (In %)	-	57.56	4.37	11.31
26	Net profit margin (In %)	(96.48)	(2,529.51)	(2.42)	(783.67)
* Ratio can not be calculated due to negative average shareholders funds.					
** Ratio can not be calculated due to negative earning available for debt service.					
# Ratio can not be calculated due to negative working capital.					
Notes:					
1 The above results have been reviewed and approved by the Board of Directors (‘the Board’) at its meeting held on 20 May 2026.					
2 The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 52(8), read with 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://embassyindia.com/tcl/) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).					
3 Figures for the quarter ended 31 March 2026 and corresponding quarter ended 31 March 2025 represent the balancing figures between the audited figures for the full financial year and published reviewed year to date figures upto third quarter of the financial year.					
Registered Office: Office No. 202, 2nd Floor, A-18, Rama House, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi- 110 001.		For and on behalf of the Board of Directors			
Place : New Delhi Date : 20 May 2026		Abhishek Rajninath Surve Whole-time director			

EMBASSY					
Embassy Developments Limited (Formerly Equinox India Developments Limited and earlier Indiabulls Real Estate Limited)					
Statement of Audited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31 March 2026					
Sl. No.	Particulars	3 months ended	Preceding 3 months ended	Previous year ended	Current year ended
		March 31, 2026	Dec. 31, 2025	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2026
		(Refer Note 4)	(Unaudited)	(Refer Note 3)	(Audited)
1	Total income from operations	3,424.63	2,127.82	8,888.89	17,318.32
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the year/period (before Tax, Minority Interest and Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(3,489.12)	(2,338.86)	1,572.63	(8,974.83)
3	Net (Loss) / Profit for the year/period before Tax and Minority Interest (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(3,448.74)	(2,382.63)	1,292.63	(8,973.22)
4	Net (Loss) / Profit for the year/period after Tax and Minority Interest (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(3,234.32)	(2,333.39)	1,229.83	(8,724.75)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the year/period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the year/period (after tax) and				
6	Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(3,232.26)	(2,402.26)	1,410.23	(8,774.22)
7	Earnings per Share (of ₹ 2/- each) - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(2.33) (2.33)	(1.67) (1.67)	1.06 0.90	(6.43) (6.43)
8	Paid up Equity Share Capital	2780.07	2780.07	2443.88	2780.07
Notes to the unaudited consolidated financial results:					
1. The above consolidated results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and subsequently approved at the meeting of the Board of Directors held on 20th May 2026. The full year financial results have been audit by the statutory auditors of the Company.					
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly / Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://embassyindia.com) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).					
3. The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2025 represents the balancing amounts between the audited consolidated financial results for the year ended March 2025 and the management accounts prepared year to date figures upto December 31, 2024.					
4. The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of full financial year and the published year to date figures upto December 31, 2025.					
Embassy Developments Limited (Formerly Equinox India Developments Limited and earlier Indiabulls Real Estate Limited)					
Statement of Audited Standalone Financial Results for the quarter and year ended 31 March 2026					
Sl. No.	Particulars	3 months ended	Preceding 3 months ended	Previous year ended	Current year ended
		March 31, 2026	Dec. 31, 2025	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2026
		(Refer Note 4)	(Unaudited)	(Refer Note 3)	(Audited)
1	Total income from operations	958.11	312.86	5,885.68	4,121.87
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the year/period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(865.32)	(783.39)	(221.51)	(2,972.96)
3	Net (Loss) / Profit for the year/period before Tax and (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(830.01)	(810.26)	(501.51)	(2,959.52)
4	Net (Loss) / Profit for the year/period after Tax and (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(798.20)	(739.63)	(472.89)	(2,830.66)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the year/period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the year/period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(797.85)	(745.54)	(2,137.62)	(2,818.20)
6	Earnings per Share (of ₹ 2/- each) - Basic (Amount in ₹) - Diluted (Amount in ₹)	(0.57) (0.57)	(0.53) (0.53)	(0.39) (0.39)	(2.08) (2.08)
7	Paid up Equity Share Capital	2780.07	2780.07	2443.88	2780.07
Notes to the unaudited standalone financial results:					
1. The above standalone results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and subsequently approved at the meeting of the Board of Directors held on 20th May 2026. The full year financial results have been audit by the statutory auditors of the Company.					
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly / Annual Financial Results are available on the Company's website (https://embassyindia.com) and on the website of BSE (https://www.bseindia.com) and NSE (https://www.nseindia.com).					
3. The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2025 are the balancing figures between the audited standalone financial results for the year ended March 31, 2025 and the management accounts prepared year to date figures upto December 31, 2024.					
4. The figures for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 are the balancing figures between audited figures in respect of full financial year and the published year to date figures upto December 31, 2025.					
Registered Office: Office No. 01-1001, WeWork, Blue One Square, Udyog Vihar Phase 4 Rd, Gurugram, Haryana 122016		For and on behalf of the Board of Directors			
Place : Bengaluru Date : May 20, 2026		Aditya Virwani Managing Director			

Editor's
TAKE

Dowry violence remains India's ugly reality

Rising dowry deaths reflect a collective moral failure. Until society challenges the mindset that commodifies women in marriage, laws alone will not end this menace

This is sad and unfortunate, but true. The much-cherished Indian marriage institution is largely becoming transactional, as marriages are more about a give-and-take relationship than the bond between two individuals choosing to spend a lifetime together. Thanks to patriarchy rooted in the Indian psyche, dowry is considered a necessary tradition where the groom receives gifts, often in cash and kind – and the bride's family complies with the irrational demands of the groom's family, failing which the girl pays the price through mental torture and, in some cases, with her life. That is the reality today: despite decades of legislation, public campaigns, and growing awareness about women's rights, India continues to witness a disturbing rise in dowry-related violence and deaths.

Two recent incidents of alleged dowry deaths have once again exposed the continuing menace of dowry-related violence despite strict laws. One of the most disturbing cases is that of Twisha Sharma, a 33-year-old woman from Bhopal whose death triggered nationwide outrage. Reports suggested that injuries were found on her body, leading to demands for a Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe. The incident shows that dowry deaths are not limited to weaker sections but also occur in well-to-do families.

Another shocking case emerged from Greater Noida, where 24-year-old Deepika Nagar died after allegedly being thrown from the terrace of her in-laws' house. Her family accused her husband and in-laws of demanding ₹50 lakh and a Fortuner car as dowry. Police arrested the husband and father-in-law while investigations continued. These incidents prove that the scourge of dowry is still very much rampant, though it has vanished from mainstream discourse. According to NCRB data, thousands of women still lose their lives every year because of dowry harassment, exposing deep-rooted patriarchy and greed.

Dowry deaths are registered under Section 80 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Yet, even with the Dowry Prohibition Act in force since 1961, implementation remains weak and convictions are few. At the heart of the problem lies patriarchy. In many families, daughters are still viewed as financial burdens, while marriage is treated as a means to enhance status through gifts, cash, or property. Rising consumerism has worsened the situation, with demands extending beyond traditional gifts to luxury cars, apartments, and expensive lifestyles. Another major reason is silence. Many women endure emotional abuse, violence, and coercion in silence.

The way forward requires more than stricter laws. Legal provisions already exist, but enforcement must become faster and more effective. Women's economic empowerment is another critical step. Greater access to education, employment, and property rights can help women gain independence and resist abusive situations. But most importantly, society must change and create stronger support systems for victims. Ultimately, it is a menace that can only be controlled through a changed mindset, as law alone cannot prevent it.

Beijing's Thucydides gambit

By invoking the ancient Greek concept of the 'Thucydides Trap,' Chinese President Xi Jinping sought to frame the US-China rivalry not as a temporary dispute but as a structural contest embedded in the logic of history itself



BHASKAR
JYOTI
MAHANTA

The ancient Greek historian Thucydides observed that the Peloponnesian War became inevitable because of the rise of the power of ancient Athens and the fear it generated in Sparta, which was the dominant power at that time. The historical construct of the "Thucydides Trap" was popularised by Harvard professor Graham Allison, who warned that when a rising power threatens to displace an established superpower, structural friction frequently culminates in war.

Occurring against a backdrop of global economic turbulence, Middle Eastern instability involving Iran, and an unrelenting tech war, the recently concluded US-China summit was heavily scrutinised for its symbolic and structural implications.

In Beijing, this ancient Greek thesis was intentionally revived, serving as the canvas upon which China painted a complex, multi-layered strategic narrative. During the opening sessions at the Great Hall of the People, President Xi explicitly invoked Allison's coinage, asking President Trump whether their respective nations could "overcome the Thucydides Trap and establish a new paradigm for relations between great powers." Far from a casual academic reference, this query encapsulated China's multi-pronged messaging strategy directed at both the White House and the global community.

The narrative posits that friction is an inevitable law of history, thereby demanding mutual accommodation. Xi's framing subtly pressured the United States to treat China as a geopolitical equal, arguing that "Planet Earth is vast enough to accommodate the respective development and common prosperity" of both powers. Beneath the diplomatic vocabulary lay a stark, conditional warning. Chinese state media and Foreign Ministry spokespersons quickly tethered the Thucydides metaphor to the Taiwan question. The messaging was clear: avoiding the "trap" of open conflict is entirely contingent on Washington respecting Beijing's red lines. Xi explicitly noted that mishandling Taiwan would push the relationship into "dangerous" territory, effectively communicating that if the trap snaps shut, it would be due to American provocations on cross-strait sovereignty.

Concurrently, China targeted international observers, particularly the Global South and European markets. By publicly asking whether conflict could be avoided, Beijing positioned itself as the responsible, rational actor seeking "tactical stabilisation" and global predictability, contrasting its posture with the perceived volatility of the Trump administration's trans-



CHINA YIELDED NO GROUND ON TAIWAN, SUCCESSFULLY REINFORCING ITS DETERRENCE POSTURE WITHOUT PROVOKING IMMEDIATE ESCALATION. ON IRAN, BEIJING AVOIDED MAKING CONCRETE CONCESSIONS, KEEPING ITS STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP WITH TEHRAN INTACT WHILE PLAYING THE ROLE OF A DETACHED DIPLOMATIC OBSERVER

The writer is a former DGP of Assam and General Secretary of the think tank 'SHARE'

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 bhaskar-mahanta-ips-ret-d-a8a1a27b

actional foreign policy. The meticulous choreography of the summit revealed deep-seated mutual suspicion, particularly within the digital domain. Behind-the-scenes preparations were heavily shaped by defensive cybersecurity measures and radically divergent strategic expectations. The summit took place immediately following intense domestic friction regarding "AI distillation attacks." In the months leading up to May 2026, leading American AI firms — including OpenAI and Anthropic — disclosed industrial-scale cyber campaigns aimed at harvesting proprietary algorithmic models, pointing directly to Chinese threat actors. In response, the White House issued National Security Presidential Memorandum (NSPM-4), elevating these digital extraction campaigns to a core national security threat.

Consequently, cybersecurity precautions for the US delegation were unprecedented. Air-gapped communication networks, highly encrypted satellite links, and strict physical and digital isolation of devices were implemented to prevent espionage. On the Chinese side, cyber defences were heightened to prevent retaliatory data poisoning or disruptive countermeasures by US intelligence. Furthermore, the presence of high-profile tech leaders such as Elon Musk, Tim Cook, and Jensen Huang in Trump's delegation turned the summit venue into a virtual fortress of intellectual property protection, with both sides treating digital networks as live combat zones.

The two leaders entered the summit room with fundamentally incompatible frameworks. President Trump approached the bilateral meeting through a highly transactional lens. Flanked by American CEOs, his expectations were heavily weighted towards concrete commercial concessions: extracting large-scale Chinese commitments to purchase US soybeans, liquefied natural gas (LNG), and Boeing aircraft. Additionally, Washington prioritised pressuring Beijing to leverage its oil-buyer relationship with Tehran to de-escalate the Middle Eastern crisis.

President Xi, on the other hand, preferred a structural and institutional approach. Facing domestic economic headwinds, low consumer demand, and real estate vulnerabilities, Beijing sought a prolonged runway of stability. Its primary objective was to maintain the October 2025 Busan trade truce, avoid impending Section 301 tariffs on industrial overcapacity, and prevent further tightening of US restrictions on mid-tier semiconductors.

As Air Force One departed Beijing, the summit was widely categorised by international analysts as the "Stalemate Summit." While President Trump characteristically declared that they had "settled a lot of different problems," the actual readouts revealed a lack of structural breakthroughs, resulting in a highly managed tactical equilibrium.

However, the US achieved notable short-term commercial gains. Trump secured renewed Chinese promises to honour agricultural and energy import quotas, providing a political boost to his domestic base. Furthermore, the codification of the January 2026 TikTok joint venture — where American investors take majority control while Oracle oversees algorithmic security — was presented as a successful blueprint for handling Chinese tech expansion. On geopolitics, Washington succeeded in forcing China to publicly acknowledge the shared risk of a prolonged blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, given Beijing's reliance on Middle Eastern energy.

China achieved its core objective - namely, buying time. By preventing a breakdown of the

Busan truce, Beijing preserved its export pipelines to the US until at least November 2026. Given that recent US Supreme Court rulings had limited the presidency's emergency powers to impose

sweeping tariffs, Xi managed to exploit American domestic institutional divisions, effectively weakening Trump's tariff leverage.

Moreover, China yielded no ground on Taiwan, successfully reinforcing its deterrence posture without provoking immediate escalation. On Iran, Beijing avoided making concrete concessions, keeping its strategic partnership with Tehran intact while playing the role of a detached diplomatic observer.

Ultimately, the 2026 Beijing Summit did not resolve the systemic rivalry that characterises the US-China relationship, nor did it permanently dismantle the Thucydides Trap. Instead, it served as an elaborate mechanism for relationship management. By utilising the vocabulary of ancient history, China successfully signalled the catastrophic costs of conflict, while the United States leveraged the meeting to secure immediate transactional concessions. The final outcome was a fragile, heavily managed stabilisation — a diplomatic truce that temporarily lowered the geopolitical temperature, even as both powers continued to build up their cyber, economic, and military assets for a prolonged historic confrontation.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

An open letter to the young lives lost too soon



ASHA IYER
KUMAR

2ND OPINION

Dear children,
You may never read this open letter I am writing to you — or perhaps you will, from the balcony of the world you chose to ascend to after the NEET-UG examination was cancelled. Already distressed by the paper leak and the lapse in the system, the news of your deaths came as a horror to me, and I am crestfallen. I sincerely wish to have a conversation with you, between the two realms to which we now belong. This is not a newspaper column; it is a heartfelt epistle written in the knowledge that I may never receive a reply. Or perhaps I will — from those who read this — and their responses may help stop the growing trend of young people choosing self-annihilation instead of courage and confidence when the system fails them.

The first question that comes to my mind is this: what on earth made you end your lives for a mistake that was never yours? I understand that your years of hard work seemed wasted. Your dreams shattered into smithereens, and suddenly you felt stranded in darkness. But who told you there was no light beyond it? Which devil convinced you that this was the end of the road? Why did suicide appear to be the only response to this crisis?

I have often tried to understand the logic behind taking one's own life. Statistics suggest that there are nearly 14 to 15 million suicide attempts worldwide every year, of which around 720,000 end in death. I deliberately avoid saying people "succeed" in suicide because choosing death when life still stretches ahead can never be called a triumph.

Life has a way of disrupting plans and pushing people to the edge. I, too, have gone through moments when the future appeared bleak and death seemed easier than enduring life's burdens. I have had fleeting thoughts of escape. But those thoughts always passed. Over time, I realised that the future still holds possibilities, however hidden they may appear in moments of despair. The struggles we endure often shape us into stronger and wiser human beings.

I must confess — as many others would — that thoughts of escaping life's harshness are not uncommon. What

keeps most of us going is faith: faith that setbacks are temporary and that life offers more than one path. But in your case, you believed that this setback was permanent, that there was no life beyond becoming a doctor. Dear children, what happened to you was deeply unfair, but it could never have determined your entire future. One examination could not define what you were

destined to become. There are countless ways to fulfil one's dreams, and there are many dreams worth pursuing. Life never offers only one route to success. Sadly, no one may have told you that — not your parents, teachers, or guardians. People

often say suicide is not a solution. Perhaps you were not even seeking one. Perhaps you were only trying to escape the pain and humiliation that overwhelmed you. But you had not failed. The system had. That you paid with your lives for someone else's failure is heartbreaking. You could have become symbols of hope for future generations. Instead, your deaths have become reminders of despair. I only wish someone had taught you that life renews itself every day with fresh opportunities. Your lives were precious, and it is tragic that you could not see it. You had not reached a dead end; you merely mistook a curtain for a wall and stopped walking.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist, independent journalist and children's writing coach

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PHYSICAL INACTIVITY: A GROWING GLOBAL CONCERN

A recent report published in Nature Medicine, analysing data from 68 countries, reveals that physical activity levels have remained stagnant over the past two decades despite increasing awareness and policy recommendations. Globally, around 80 per cent of adolescents and one in three adults fail to meet the World Health Organization's prescribed physical activity guidelines. This makes the WHO's target of reducing physical inactivity by 15 per cent by 2030 appear increasingly difficult to achieve.

The issue is particularly serious in developing countries such as India. The 2026 Time Use Survey showed that only one in ten Indians exercised on a given day in 2024, most of them men. For millions living in overcrowded cities, leisure and

exercise have become luxuries amid long commutes, demanding work schedules and inadequate public infrastructure. Another study in Nature Health highlighted poor implementation of physical activity policies, noting that many countries failed to set measurable targets for assessing progress.

The challenge now is to democratise physical activity. Governments must treat exercise as a civic necessity rather than a personal choice alone. Cities need pedestrian-friendly roads, parks and cycling tracks, while workplaces should encourage movement instead of prolonged sedentary routines. Women and marginalised communities must also have safe access to public spaces for recreation and exercise.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Brewing hope, one cup at a time

Tea is the world's second most consumed beverage after water, cherished across cultures and generations. Whether enjoyed early in the morning, during a midday break, or on a quiet evening, tea offers comfort, warmth and a sense of togetherness. It is often said that buying tea is akin to buying happiness. While every day may feel like "tea day", the United Nations officially observes International Tea Day on May 21 each year.

The 2026 theme, "Fostering Growth and Inclusion", highlights the need to empower tea farmers and strengthen livelihoods linked to the tea industry. Tea supports millions of families, especially in economically weaker and remote regions, while also symbolising cultural heritage and diversity. The UN continues to promote tea as a tool for sustainable development, poverty reduction, hunger eradication and women's empowerment.

At the same time, challenges such as climate change and declining tea production require urgent attention.

As the saying goes, life is like making tea — boil the ego, evaporate worry, dilute sorrow and filter mistakes. The result is a happier and richer life.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Revision in auto-taxi fares

This refers to the report, "*Cab, auto drivers' unions call 3-day strike*" (May 20). The commercial vehicle unions in Delhi-NCR have disturbed not only the peaceful sleep of the Delhi government and officials but also that of commuters by announcing a three-day strike. Consequently, the possibility of an increased financial burden falling upon common people — who already rely on expensive taxi services — has become stronger.

According to the "Chalak Shakti Union", taxi fare slabs in Delhi-NCR have remained unchanged for the past 15 years, even as fuel prices and operational costs have steadily increased. This has reportedly disrupted the financial balance of drivers' earnings. By submitting memorandums to the Chief Minister, Transport Minister, Lieutenant Governor and Police Commissioner of Delhi, the union has further intensified the issue by extending support to the nationwide protest call given by the All India Motor Transport Congress. On the other hand, the general public points out that many auto-rickshaw drivers frequently claim their meters are out of order to justify charging arbitrary and exorbitant fares. As a result, people now prefer app-based services such as Ola, Uber and Rapido for safer travel. The government must consider the burden on common people before revising fares.

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

Balancing human safety and animal welfare

Apropos, "SC refuses to recall order on sterilisation of stray dogs" (May 20). The Supreme Court's refusal to dilute its directions on removing stray dogs from public institutions is a timely and necessary intervention in an escalating public safety crisis. For years, civic authorities across the country have failed to address the alarming rise in dog-bite incidents, forcing the judiciary to step into what has effectively become an administrative vacuum.

The ground reality today is deeply concerning. Children near schools, elderly citizens on morning walks, and residents in housing colonies often live in fear of aggressive stray dog packs. The Court has rightly observed that humane treatment of animals cannot come at the cost of human safety, just as public safety cannot justify cruelty towards animals. The solution lies in striking a careful balance. Municipal authorities must now match the Court's directions with serious investments in shelters, sterilisation centres, vaccination drives, and veterinary care facilities. The issue cannot be resolved through knee-jerk reactions or violence. Instead, local administrations must develop a humane, accountable and effective stray management system that safeguards both citizens and animal welfare.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Great Nicobar project: Balancing strategy, ecology and national interest

Great Nicobar Island occupies one of the most strategic locations in the world. Situated close to the Malacca Strait, through which a substantial portion of global maritime trade passes, the island offers India a unique opportunity to strengthen its presence in the Indian Ocean



VK BAHUGUNA

The Great Nicobar Development Project proposal of the Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India, stands at an important stage for the future geo-strategic dominance of the country in trade and defence. The proposed project, which includes an international transhipment

port, airport, power infrastructure, roads, and an urban township, has generated intense debate across the country. To some, it represents India's strategic and economic future in the Indo-Pacific region. To naysayers, it is a threat to fragile biodiversity and indigenous tribal communities. The truth, however, lies not in extreme positions but in finding a balanced and workable path that protects both national interest and environmental responsibility.

Great Nicobar Island occupies one of the most strategic locations in the world. Situated close to the Malacca Strait (40 to 90 nautical miles away), through which a substantial portion of global maritime trade passes, the island offers India a unique opportunity to strengthen its presence in the Indian Ocean. At present, a major share of Indian cargo depends upon foreign transhipment hubs such as Singapore and Colombo. A modern port in Great Nicobar could reduce this dependence, improve India's trade competitiveness, and strengthen maritime self-reliance. The strategic significance of the island goes beyond economics. In an era of rising geopolitical competition in the Indo-Pacific, India requires stronger naval logistics, surveillance capability, and rapid-response infrastructure in the Andaman and Nicobar region. The project, therefore, has undeniable defence value. Stronger infrastructure in the islands would enhance India's maritime security and reinforce its role as a leading regional power. At the same time, critics of the project have raised legitimate concerns. Great Nicobar is home to dense tropical forests, mangroves, coral reefs, and several rare species such as the globally threatened Nicobar Megapode, Nicobar Tree Shrew, crab-eating long-tailed macaque, and Giant Leatherback Sea Turtle. Environmental groups fear that large-scale construction may damage fragile ecosystems and threaten wildlife habitats.

The island is also ecologically vulnerable because of earthquakes, tsunamis, and rising sea levels. The devastating tsunami of 2004 remains a reminder that the Nicobar region cannot be treated like an ordinary urban expansion zone. Some people have also raised concerns regarding indigenous communities such as the semi-nomadic Shompen tribe, recognised as a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group, which has lived in relative isolation for centuries. According to critics, uncontrolled urbanisation could disturb their traditional lifestyle and cause cultural disruption. However, it is also necessary to place the debate in perspective. Opponents argue that tribal reserves must remain inviolable and completely insulated from commercial expansion, tourism, and migration pressures. On the other hand, I am a strong proponent of bringing tribal communities into mainstream society for development, healthcare, education, and employment, based on my 40 years of experience in tribal-dominated states of North-East and Central India. What is needed is the preservation of tribal languages, music, art, and cultural practices, including indigenous medicine.

An integrated tribal development project should be implemented by the Forest Department not only in the project area but across the entire Andaman and Nicobar Union Territory. Since the area is prone to earthquakes and tsunamis, infrastructure must be designed to withstand earthquakes, cyclones, and tsunamis through advanced engineering standards. Reports indicate that the actual core development area constitutes less than 1 per cent of the total island area. This means the challenge before policymakers is not whether development should happen, but how it should happen responsibly. In this regard, one aspect of the proposal that needs modification is the plan for a massive township of nearly six lakh people. Such a large urban settlement may place



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

THE STRATEGIC SIGNIFICANCE OF THE ISLAND GOES BEYOND ECONOMICS. IN AN ERA OF RISING GEOPOLITICAL COMPETITION IN THE INDO-PACIFIC, INDIA REQUIRES STRONGER NAVAL LOGISTICS, SURVEILLANCE CAPABILITY, AND RAPID-RESPONSE INFRASTRUCTURE IN THE ANDAMAN AND NICOBAR REGION. THE PROJECT, THEREFORE, HAS UNDENIABLE DEFENCE VALUE

The writer is former Director-General ICFRE and Chairman of Centre for Resource Management and Environment

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unsustainable pressure on the fragile island ecosystem. A more realistic and nationally prudent approach would be to limit the township population to around 50,000 to one lakh people, primarily consisting of defence personnel, port workers, researchers, administrators, and trade-related professionals. Great Nicobar should therefore become a strategic trade and defence hub rather than a densely populated commercial city.

Environmental safeguards must also become central to the project, and the Forest Department should be empowered under the Environmental Protection Act, 1986, to constantly monitor developmental activities, sea pollution, and ensure the protection of biodiversity and the overall environment.

Sensitive areas such as turtle nesting beaches, coral reefs, mangroves, and primary forests should remain protected as no-development zones. Construction should follow strict green standards with renewable energy systems, controlled waste management, rainwater harvesting, and disaster-resilient infrastructure. Development should proceed in carefully monitored phases rather than through uncontrolled expansion.

In a nutshell, India today requires infrastructure, maritime capability, and economic strength to secure its place in the changing global order as a global power. At the same time, development that destroys ecological wealth and cultural heritage cannot truly serve national interest. Strategic progress and environmental conservation must therefore go hand in hand.

The Great Nicobar Project should not become a victim of either blind opposition or reckless expansionism. India must pursue a middle path — one that combines strategic necessity with ecological wisdom. A carefully regulated, defence- and trade-oriented development model with limited urbanisation can ensure that Great Nicobar strengthens India's future without compromising its environmental and moral responsibilities.

The real success of the project will not be measured merely by the size of its port or township, but by whether India can demonstrate that it can emerge as a global power in the Indian Ocean without harming its ecology. The Great Nicobar Project must therefore be implemented both efficiently and carefully. Since the proposal is being piloted by the Home Ministry, it needs to be fine-tuned after discussions with the Andaman Forest Department and the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change before it is put out for tendering or assigned to an implementing agency.

India's national interest requires strategic depth along with environmental stability. A smarter, carefully regulated, defence — and trade-oriented development model would allow India to secure its maritime future while preserving biodiversity and protecting indigenous communities. If planned wisely, Great Nicobar can become an example of sustainable strategic development rather than a case of ecological overexpansion.

Congress cannot afford another Karnataka mistake



TEHSEEN POONAWALLA

Indian politics has a cruel way of exposing weakness. It does not merely punish defeat; it punishes indecision, hesitation, and the inability to learn from repeated mistakes. That is precisely where the Congress party finds itself today.

There is an old political saying that parties in decline eventually learn how to lose. Over the past decade, the Congress seems to have turned that lesson into routine practice. The tragedy for the party is that many of these defeats are not inevitable. Often, the Congress enters contests with enough political space, public dissatisfaction against its opponents, and organisational presence to remain competitive. Yet, the examples are many. Haryana and Madhya Pradesh remain painful reminders. In both states, the Congress was not irrelevant. It was in the contest. It had momentum, visibility, and voter support. Yet, in both instances, it failed to convert opportunity into victory. The party leadership continues to blame external factors, including allegations of electoral manipulation and "vote chori", but far less attention is paid to internal dysfunction. Delayed decisions, factional rivalries, confused messaging, and a lack of clarity in leadership continue to haunt the party.

For Congress supporters, this is perhaps the most frustrating aspect. These are not new problems. They are recurring patterns. Every election seems to expose the same weaknesses in different forms. At the centre of this crisis lies a simple but critical issue: the inability to place the right person in the right role at the right time.

Voters may disagree with a party's ideology, but they rarely forgive confusion. The Congress often appears unsure of itself. It hesitates when it should act, debates when it should decide, and second-guesses itself when political instinct demands confidence. Its opponents have understood this far better. The Bharatiya Janata Party operates with a level of organisational aggression and strategic clarity that the Congress has struggled to match. The contrast between the two leadership styles is striking. In the race between a diabetic Amit Shah and a seemingly fitter Rahul Gandhi, the former consistently wins not because of physical energy, but because of political agility, sharper decision-making, and organisational discipline.

Karnataka is not just another Congress-ruled state. It is the party's southern anchor, one of the few major states where it still possesses organisational strength, leadership depth, and electoral viability. Losing Karnataka would not simply reduce the Congress tally by one more state. Psychologically, it would be devastating. It would deepen the national perception that the party is incapable of retaining even its strongest remaining bastions.

And yet, even in Karnataka, familiar fault lines are emerging. The leadership tussle between Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar is no longer an internal matter whispered about in political corridors. It has become public, visible, and constant. The media tracks every development, every statement, and every signal from Delhi. Naturally, voters are watching too.

Both leaders bring undeniable strengths to the table. Siddaramaiah represents experience, governance, and a social coalition that has historically benefited the Congress. DK Shivakumar, meanwhile, represents organisational energy, aggressive politics, and political management. Within the party, he is often viewed as the dependable troubleshooter capable of keeping the organisation functioning during difficult times. The problem is not the existence of two strong leaders. The problem is the inability of the party leadership to clearly define how both leaders fit into the future structure of power. Earlier signals suggested that DK Shivakumar might eventually get an opportunity to lead the state. Those signals now appear uncertain. The high command once again seems trapped in hesitation.

This indecision is dangerous because politics does not wait. Time is never neutral. Delay almost always benefits the opponent. Uncertainty at the top filters down rapidly. Workers begin forming camps. Rivalries deepen. Authority weakens. By the time Karnataka heads into the next Assembly election, unresolved tensions could become a serious liability for the Congress. There is also a generational dimension to this debate. Many within the party believe DK Shivakumar represents the future. His style is more combative, more aggressive, and arguably more aligned with the current political mood of the country. Siddaramaiah, while respected for his administrative experience, represents continuity with an older political approach. Neither model is inherently wrong. But the Congress appears unable to decide which direction it truly wants to embrace.

This broader drift now defines the party nationally. The Congress frequently builds momentum only to squander it. It raises expectations and then fails to meet them. It gets close to victory and then retreats at the decisive moment. "Pulling defeat from the jaws of victory" has increasingly become associated with the party. Why does this continue to happen? One reason lies in structure. The Congress still functions through an overly centralised high-command culture. State leaders often wait endlessly for approval from Delhi instead of acting decisively on the ground. This slows responses and weakens political momentum. A second reason lies in unmanaged ambition. Political ambition is natural and even necessary. But when ambition is not balanced through timely decisions, it turns into rivalry. Rivalry without resolution eventually leads to paralysis.

A third reason is the absence of a coherent narrative. Too often, voters remain unsure about what the Congress stands for in a specific election. Local concerns get mixed with vague national positioning. Messaging becomes cluttered, inconsistent, and uninspiring. The Kerala victory demonstrates that the Congress is not politically irrelevant. It can still mobilise support and win elections under the right circumstances. This is why Karnataka matters so profoundly. The state presents the Congress with an opportunity to prove that it can still act decisively - an opportunity to demonstrate that leadership conflicts can be resolved before they become destructive, and an opportunity to show that it can protect and strengthen what remains of its political map.

The solution itself is not particularly complicated. The party must settle the leadership question early. It must clearly define roles. It must prevent factional warfare from spilling into public view. Above all, it must project unity and confidence. Politics ultimately rewards those who act with clarity and conviction. It punishes hesitation. Right now, hesitation remains the Congress party's biggest enemy.



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 The Pioneer

Mandate for a new Bengal: Be royal again, be great again!



SAYAN CHATTERJEE

been mere arithmetic; they are textured, almost cultural expressions shaped by identity, emotion, and an evolving idea of justice. This time, however, beneath the cadence of campaign rhetoric and the machinery of party politics, a quieter but more consequential shift is discernible. After fifteen years of continuity, Bengal is not simply weighing a change of guard — it is reconsidering what it expects from power itself.

At the centre of this transition stands an unlikely figure: Ratna Debnath. Neither a career politician nor a product of institutional grooming, she enters public life as a mother marked by loss and reshaped by it. Her political journey does not follow the familiar arc of ambition; it emerges instead from disruption — personal, moral, and ultimately civic. Until recently, she existed outside the conventional contours of political relevance, working within communities, engaging with local concerns, and building a presence that was neither headline-driven nor strategically curated. Yet today, she has

come to embody one of the most compelling shifts in Bengal's political narrative. Her victory in the Panihati Assembly constituency is significant not merely because she has won, but because of what her win unsettles. Panihati, located in North 24 Parganas, has long been defined by structure — dense grassroots networks, organisational loyalty, and a consistent inclination towards the Trinamool Congress. Electoral outcomes here were historically shaped less by individual candidatures and more by the durability of party machinery. In 2026, that script has been meaningfully altered.

Contesting on a Bharatiya Janata Party ticket, Debnath secured a decisive margin — one that moved beyond statistical comfort into the realm of unmistakable public endorsement. The contest, featuring TMC's Tirthankar Ghosh and CPI(M)'s Kalatan Dasgupta, ultimately reflected the bipolar dynamic that has increasingly come to define Bengal's electoral landscape. Yet within this familiar polarity, something distinctly unfamiliar unfolded.

Debnath did not arrive with a legacy of political inheritance or an entrenched organisational base. What she carried instead was a narrative — one that the electorate did not merely register but internalise. The "Abhaya" case, as it came to be widely known, transcended the contours of a criminal investigation to become a rupture in Bengal's collective conscience. The alleged sexual assault and death of her daughter, a young trainee doctor at RG Kar Medical College and Hospital, catal-



ysed a broader public introspection on women's safety, institutional accountability, and the perceived distance between governance and justice. In the months that followed, the discourse evolved from immediate outrage into something more enduring. It became a mirror, reflecting anxieties long present but seldom articulated with such urgency. Urban constituencies like Panihati, marked by political awareness and media visibility, absorbed this discourse in layered ways. Voter behaviour did not abandon its reliance on organisational strength, but it expanded its evaluative lens. Credibility remained central - but its meaning evolved.

For decades, credibility in such constituencies was synonymous with organisational depth and political continuity. In 2026, it began to be measured through lived experience and perceived integrity. This shift, though subtle, is consequential. It signals an electorate that is no longer sat-

isied with representation that is merely functional; it seeks representation that resonates.

Panihati, in this sense, becomes a microcosm of a broader transformation. It moves from predictability to empathy, from structure to sentiment, from alignment to assertion. Ratna Debnath's victory, therefore, is not just another electoral outcome; it reads as a quiet yet pointed commentary for any government that occupies, or aspires to occupy, the seat of power. It suggests that Bengal, even if momentarily, is willing to suspend its entrenched loyalties to acknowledge a different kind of political legitimacy — one that is neither inherited nor engineered, but earned through an unfiltered connection with public emotion.

This is not to suggest that Bengal's deeply rooted political frameworks have weakened. They remain potent, relevant, and often determinative. What this election reveals, however, is that within these structures there is now space — however narrow — for disruption. For individuals who do not conform to the mould yet possess the ability to redefine it. Embedded within this moment is also a larger question for governance. When an electorate responds so emphatically to a narrative born out of institutional failure, it is not merely endorsing a candidate — it is issuing a reminder that governance is not only about delivery, but about trust; not only about systems, but about how those systems respond under strain.

In that sense, this result is as much a mandate as it is a message. Governance has prevailed — but not in the conventional sense of administrative effi-

ciency or policy articulation. It has met its most fundamental expectation: listening, acknowledging, and responding. Debnath's journey — from enduring an unspeakable personal loss to stepping into public life and earning the mandate of a constituency — captures a transformation that is often invoked but rarely witnessed with such clarity: the conversion of private grief into public leadership.

It is a reminder that politics, at its most consequential, is not about control — it is about connection. And perhaps that is the deeper takeaway for what has long been regarded as India's cultural capital. If the system falters, people may no longer wait for its correction; they may instead seek to become the system themselves. For Bengal, a state that has historically prided itself on intellectual and cultural leadership, this moment offers an inflection point — to reimagine not just its politics, but its priorities.

To align governance with empathy. To ensure justice is not episodic but embedded. To rebuild trust not through rhetoric, but through response. Bengal has turned a page. Whether it evolves into a chapter of renewal or remains a brief departure from continuity will depend on what follows. For now, however, one conclusion is inescapable: the electorate has spoken — not just in numbers, but in nuance.

The writer is a Delhi-based independent contributor to print and online publications

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Order Order

SC seeks response on plea to ban sale of liquor in tetra packs

The Supreme Court on Wednesday sought responses from the Centre and others on a plea seeking direction to forthwith ban the sale of alcohol in packaging such as tetra packs and sachets. A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi agreed to hear the petition filed by organisation 'Community Against Drunken Driving'. Advocate Vipin Nair, appearing for the petitioner, said that definition of bottle was "vague" under the excise regime and some standardisation has to come in this regard. "They are confusing fruit juice with liquor. They use photo of apple and the pack contains Vodka," he said, adding the State has the duty to protect the health of citizens. (PTI)



SC rejects PIL challenging caste enumeration during Census

The Supreme Court on Wednesday rejected a PIL challenging the Centre's decision to conduct caste-based Census, saying the issue falls under the policy domain. The top court said the government must know the number of persons belonging to backward castes to frame welfare measures. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul Pancholi did not agree to the submissions of PIL petitioner Sudhakar Gummula, who appeared in person to argue his case, that plenty of information and figures were available with the government on caste details. "These are all policy matters, whether the Census should be caste-based or not. What is wrong with it? The government must know as to how many people are in the backward class, what kind of welfare measures are to be taken for them. It is within the policy domain," the CJ said while dismissing the PIL. (PTI)



Ensure Aadhaar is used strictly as identity proof: Plea in SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Alleging that Aadhaar is being used as a proof of citizenship, domicile, and residential address, a PIL has been filed in the Supreme Court seeking directions to ensure that the card is used strictly as an identity proof.

The plea filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay has sought directions to the Centre, states and the Election Commission of India to ensure that Aadhaar is used as a proof of identity, not as a proof of citizenship, domicile, address and date of birth.



The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey, also sought directions that the use of Aadhaar as a proof of date of birth and residence in the application form



SC seeks response on women lawyers in Govt panels

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday sought responses from the Centre, all states and Union Territories on a PIL seeking 30 per cent quota for women lawyers in government panels and law officer positions.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi took note of the submissions of senior advocate and Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) president Vikas Singh and issued notices to the Centre and others on the PIL filed by the Ladli Foundation Trust.

The PIL sought a direction

to the Centre, state governments, and Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) to implement a minimum 30 per cent quota for women across all legal tiers, from the Supreme Court panels to local legal aid authorities.

At the outset, Singh said the PIL has been filed following the survey conducted by the SCBA on status and representation of women lawyers in the legal profession.

"They needed to be included in government panels," the senior lawyer said.

The CJ said on Tuesday some representatives of a Telangana bar body met him and he was pleasantly surprised to know that a woman lawyer has been appointed



secretary there.

"She was thanking me. I enquired about the total strength of the Bar .. it is 19,000. Around 8,000 (advocates) come regularly, out of

which 2,000 are women. Now only one woman member is appointed," the CJ said. Singh said the SCBA also proposes to file a separate PIL keeping in mind difficulties

being faced by women lawyers.

The plea refers to startling empirical evidence to say that while women are entering law schools in record numbers, they are systematically blocked from professional advancement.

"Ladli Foundation Trust is filing the present PIL under Article 32 of the Constitution seeking issuance of an appropriate writ, order or direction for a minimum of 30 per cent reservation/representation for women advocates in all governmental panels, including but not limited to the Supreme Court panels, high court panels, government law officer positions, legal aid panels and all

Central and State Government/PSU empanelments, so as to secure effective enforcement of the fundamental rights guaranteed under Articles 14, 15(3), 19(1)(g) and 21 of the Constitution," the plea said.

Citing the India Justice Report of 2022 and the SCBA survey, the plea said in over 75 years of independence, no woman has ever been appointed as Attorney General or Solicitor General of India.

"In the 35 years since Justice M Fathima Beevi became the first woman judge of the Supreme Court in 1989, only 11 women have ever been elevated to the Supreme Court of India.

CBI court acquits IT officer after 19 years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thane

A court here has acquitted a suspended Income Tax Officer and his wife in a 2007 case of disproportionate assets, pulling up the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) for an "erroneous" and "casual" investigation.

Invoking a Supreme Court precedent, Special CBI Court Judge DS Deshmukh on Tuesday said that a defendant in a corruption case does not need to prove innocence beyond a reasonable doubt, and a preponderance of probability is sufficient.

The court acquitted Anil Ratnakar Mallel (45), an Income Tax Officer then posted in Maharashtra's Thane, and his wife Suvarna Anil Mallel (43) of charges under the Prevention of Corruption Act



and Section 109 of the Indian Penal Code (abatement).

The CBI Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB), Mumbai, registered the case in January 2007, alleging that between September 1991 and December 2006, Anil Mallel misused his official position to amass wealth in his and his family's name.

While the initial FIR pegged the disproportionate assets at ₹15.34 lakh, the CBI escalated the figure to ₹28,57,984 in its final

chargesheet filed in November 2008.

During the trial, defence lawyer MS More argued that the CBI completely ignored valid sources of cash flow, including a joint housing loan of ₹8 lakh taken by Mallel's wife and his late mother, independent I-T returns filed by the wife since 2000, General Provident Fund withdrawals, and documented loans taken from relatives.

The CBI had also wrongfully classified ₹2.43 lakh in cash found during a house search as Mallel's personal asset, despite formal letters sent to the agency by his mother claiming ownership of the money, he said.

The court, while striking down the prosecution's case, said various admissions by the investigation officer during cross-examination show that he has not properly considered the income of the accused.

HC grants anticipatory bail to one Bareilly violence accused

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has granted an anticipatory bail plea to Altamas Khan, one of the accused in last year's Bareilly violence case.

Justice Ashutosh Srivastava on Monday allowed the anticipatory bail application of Altamas Khan.

According to the police case, on September 26 last year, Maulana Tauqeer Raza



had given a call for members of a particular community to assemble at Islamiya Inter College in Bareilly.

Despite prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS being in force, a crowd of about 500 people gathered, proceeding from Maulana Azad Inter College towards Shyamganj Chauraha. The crowd, holding boards and raising provocative slogans, paid little heed to the warn-

ings and persuasions made by the police personnel at the spot.

The situation escalated when the accused persons became aggressive and adamant to proceed.

Thereafter, allegedly, brickbats, stones and acid bottles were thrown at the police force by the accused persons in the crowd, and gunshots were also fired from the crowd at the police personnel.

Hold Bengaluru civic body polls by Aug 31: SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday extended till August 31 the time for holding the long-pending elections for the Bengaluru civic body.

The tenure of the earlier elected body for the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP) expired on September 10, 2020, and since then a government-appointed administrator was taking care of its day-to-day affairs.

On January 12, the apex court had asked the Karnataka government and the state election body to hold the polls for the Bengaluru civic body by June 30.



On Wednesday, a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi extended the time till August 31 and made clear that no further

extension would be granted.

The order was passed after senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the Karnataka government, referred to the shortage of

manpower due to the Census work and the upcoming special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the state.

He urged the bench that the time to conclude the polls be extended by two to three months.

Singhvi said the budgetary allocation was also done but there would be shortage of manpower.

While extending the time, the bench observed, "You go and activate your machinery".

On January 12, the top court had said that final ward-wise reservation list shall be published by the state government by February 20.

The order was passed on

a plea of the Karnataka government which has challenged the high court's December 2020 order that directed the State Election Commission to hold BBMP elections expeditiously after finalising the electoral rolls.

The top court is monitoring the compliance of its earlier orders regarding polls to the BBMP and the newly created municipal corporations within the Greater Bengaluru Area (GBA).

In its December 2020 judgment, the high court upheld the constitutional validity of the Karnataka Municipal Corporation Third Amendment Act, 2020, which increased the number of BBMP wards.



Court acquits four in Delhi riots case



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has acquitted four men accused in the 2020 Delhi riots case, saying it would be "dangerous" to rely on the testimonies of two police personnel as their versions were contradicted by the investigation record and other evidence.

Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh was hearing the case against Sumit Kumar, Anuj, Rahul and Sachin in a case related to the alleged burning of an auto-rickshaw and vandalising and setting ablaze a shop in Karawal Nagar

during the riots.

In an order dated May 19, the court said, "I find that PW6 and PW7 (police officers) are not credible witnesses and it will be dangerous to rely upon their testimonies and find for the prosecution against the accused. I accordingly find that the prosecution has failed to prove its case against the accused."

According to the prosecution, complainant Wazid had alleged that rioters set his auto-rickshaw on fire on February 25, 2020, while another complainant, Shamshad, alleged that his shop was vandalised and torched by rioters.

J-K HC announces virtual hearings amid fuel crisis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Srinagar

The High Court of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh on Wednesday announced the adoption of virtual hearings and hybrid working arrangements as part of fuel conservation measures following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal.

A circular issued by the high court's registrar general said the measures have been adopted in view of the nationwide call for adoption of measures relating to "economic self-defence" amid concerns arising from rising crude oil prices and energy security.

The measures would remain in



force until further orders, it said.

"With effect from 21.05.2026, the high court shall encourage virtual hearings and virtual appearance

by learned counsel, subject to observance of the decorum and protocol prescribed for virtual proceedings," the circular said.

It said that during the vacation period commencing on June 8, the nominated vacation benches shall deal with the matters coming before them through virtual mode.

"However, learned advocates who, for some unavoidable reasons, are unable to participate via video conferencing mode may appear physically before the hon'ble court(s) whenever it is functioning physically," it said.

"No physical administrative inspection or visit of the districts shall be conducted till further orders. All administrative meetings shall be convened virtually," the circular added.

HC dismisses PIL to deregister AAP, disqualify Kejriwal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday dismissed a PIL seeking a direction to the Election Commission to deregister the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and disqualify its chief Arvind Kejriwal and other leaders from contesting elections for boycotting HC proceedings in the liquor policy case.

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice

Tejas Karia said the petition by Satish Kumar Aggarwal was bereft of any merit and his contention was "too far-fetched, highly misconceived and misplaced".

According to the public interest litigation (PIL), AAP was liable to be deregistered in terms of Section 29A(5) of the Representation of the People Act on account of its officer bearers and members — Kerjiwal,



Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak— boycotting the proceedings before Justice Swarana

Kanta Sharma in the liquor policy case.

The counsel for the petitioner contended that while Section 29A(5) mandates a political party to "bear true faith and allegiance to the Constitution", Kerjiwal, Sisodia and Pathak failed to adhere to the constitutional principles when they "scandalised and politicised the entire system" in the liquor policy case.

"There is nothing on

record to establish that the Respondent no. 3 (AAP) has admitted that it has no faith in the Constitution or the principles of secularism, socialism or democracy," the high court said.

The court stated that the Election Commission does not have the power to deregister a political party, and contempt of court proceedings have already been initiated against the politicians for their conduct.

TWO TMC LEADERS SEEK PROTECTION FROM POLICE ACTION

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Two Trinamool Congress leaders, including an MLA, moved the Calcutta High Court on Wednesday seeking protection from coercive action by police in connection with cases registered against them after the West Bengal assembly poll verdict.



Canning Paschim legislator Paresw Ram Das's counsel, Kishore Dutta, sought an urgent hearing in the matter while informing the court that six FIRs were lodged against his client on May 16 and claimed that many more were likely to be filed.

Dutta, who was the advocate general of West Bengal during the TMC government, told the court of Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya that he was seeking protection for his client from any coercive action in connection with the criminal cases lodged against him.

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No relief in memory prices soon, says IESA president

Consumers are likely to witness high memory prices, as no significant capacity addition is in the pipeline over the next 12-18 months, a top official of industry body IESA said on Wednesday.

India Electronics and Semiconductor Association President Ashok Chandak, on the sidelines of Bharat Digital Infrastructure Association event, told reporters that setting up a memory plant will take time to get established.

"Memory makers can not set up a plant in a few days. We are not seeing any significant capacity coming up in the next one and a half years. There will be a price rise due to high demand, and consumers will need to bear the burden," Chandak said.

The price of devices, especially smartphones, has gone up by 20-30 per cent in the last six months.

The entire memory capacity of memory chip maker Micron in India has been booked due to high demand.

Chandak said the ongoing crisis in West Asia is impacting the entire economy, and there is some impact on electronics also.

"The critical raw materials, such as petrochemical plants, diesel, manganese, chemicals, and other gases, have seen an impact. It has an impact on the economy as well. Some electronics components have also been impacted," Chandak said.

He said that India Semiconductor Mission 2.0 will bring some relief for the country and boost the semiconductor ecosystem, which will reduce dependency on imports. When asked about industry expectations on the incentives under ISM 2.0, he said that it should be more than the previous edition, which was \$10 billion. (PTI)

Škoda India sets new circuit record at Coimbatore track

Škoda Auto India has launched a new brand campaign centred on its performance credentials, marked by a national record set at the Coimbatore Automotive Sports and Technical Training (CoASTT) circuit.

The campaign, built around the idea that the "Greatest On A Track" is a "Škoda On A Track," underscores the brand's motorsport legacy and its focus on delivering dynamic capability and safety across its product range. The initiative comes as the company continues to expand its network and product portfolio in India.

"As a brand, motorsport DNA isn't a halo; it is inherent, and it comes standard across our entire range," said Ashish Gupta, Brand Director, Škoda Auto India. "This campaign is a natural extension of our strategy of democratizing performance, ensuring that every Škoda offers uncompromising dynamic capability, safety, and confidence that translates seamlessly into the real world."

To kick off the campaign, Škoda Auto India set a record for the 'Fastest Multi-Car Relay of a Single Manufacturer on a Circuit,' certified by the India Book of Records and Asia Book of Records. A fleet of five cars - Kylaq, Kushaq, Slavia, Octavia RS and Kodiaq - completed a timed relay in 12:30.97, including pit-lane changeovers.

Individually, the Octavia RS posted the fastest lap at 2:10.85 on the 3.8 km circuit, while the Kodiaq, Slavia, Kushaq and Kylaq recorded competitive lap times across segments. The relay format required consistent performance across all vehicles, highlighting the brand's focus on handling, braking and overall driving dynamics.

Gupta added that the campaign celebrates qualities such as steering precision, chassis balance and driver engagement - "intangibles that will never be captured on a spec sheet but are unmistakable behind the wheel."

With a global legacy spanning 130 years and over a century in motorsport, Škoda says the campaign reinforces its positioning as a performance-driven and safety-focused brand in India (PNS)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | MAY 21, 2026

BUSINESS11

Coal Gasification: India's Pathway to Energy Security and Economic Growth

KARUNA
GOPAL
VARTAKAVI

India's coal story is both fascinating and disturbing. The country sits on one of the world's largest coal reserves — approximately 401 billion tonnes, enough to last over two centuries at current consumption rates. And yet, every year, we spend upward of ₹12 lakh crore importing crude oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), fertilizers, and petrochemicals. Coal gasification can correct this dependence and that is exactly what Govt of India wants to do now.

As we know the global energy landscape has undergone seismic shifts since 2022. Russia's invasion of Ukraine and middle east crisis have squeezed the chokepoint through which over 20 per cent of the world's oil flows, including a large share of India's crude supply.

For India, a nation of 1.44 billion people, the world's fastest-growing economy, her ability to industrialise, create jobs, and achieve her climate commitments is fundamentally constrained by energy insecurity.

Coal gasification, the process of converting coal into a combustible synthetic gas (syngas) offers a compelling solution, if managed carefully. In fact, it may well be the most pragmatic bridge between India's hydrocarbon focused present and its renewable energy future. This article of mine highlights the engineering, economics, and promises of coal gasification.

Coal gasification — The science and the process

Coal gasification is the thermochemical conversion of coal

into a gaseous fuel, primarily a mixture of carbon monoxide (CO) and hydrogen (H₂) collectively known as syngas (synthetic gas). Unlike burning coal directly for heat or electricity, gasification transforms coal into a versatile gaseous intermediate that can be used to generate power, produce chemicals, manufacture fertilizers, create transportation fuels, and even yield hydrogen — all within a single integrated facility.

The chemistry is almost poetic. When coal, primarily carbon, is subjected to high temperatures (700°C to 1,500°C) in a controlled environment with steam (H₂O) and limited oxygen, it does not burn. Instead, it undergoes a series of reactions: partial oxidation, steam reforming, the water-gas shift reaction, and methanation.

The result is a syngas whose composition can be precisely tuned — more hydrogen for fuel cells, more CO for chemical synthesis, more methane for pipeline gas.

A spectrum of high value products

The transformative power of coal gasification lies in its product flexibility. A single integrated coal gasification complex can, in principle, produce dozens of commercially valuable outputs. This is fundamentally different from burning coal for electricity — which yields only one output and destroys all carbon in the process.

These products — Syngas (CO + H₂), Hydrogen (H₂), Methanol, Ammonia (NH₃), Synthetic Natural Gas (SNG), Liquid Fuels (CTL), Dimethyl Ether (DME), India can replace imported natural gas, create blue hydrogen bridge to green hydrogen economy, provide strategic fuel for defence and aviation.

India's energy security — A case for gasification

To understand why coal gasification matters so urgently for India, one must first grasp the sheer scale of India's energy import dependency — and its vulnerability in the current geopolitical environment.

India imports like crude oil, natural gas, urea, coking coal, ammonia, and petrochemicals. Every single one of these can, in principle, be produced from India's domestic coal through gasification.

Against this backdrop, India's National Coal Gasification Mission — which targets gasifying 100 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) of coal by 2030. It is a strategic imperative.

At 100 MTPA gasification capacity, India could theoretically produce enough syngas to generate over 20,000 MW of power, manufacture over 10 million tonnes of urea annually, and supply hundreds of millions of households with cooking gas — all from domestic resources, insulated from global price shocks and geopolitical disruptions.

Slashing the import bill: Forex, CAD, and strategic sovereignty

The arithmetic of import substitution through coal gasification is compelling. Methanol produced from coal gasification can be blended with petrol at 15-85 per cent ratios, directly displacing crude oil imports. India's methanol demand, if fully met domestically through coal gasification, could save the country an estimated \$5-8 billion annually in petroleum imports.

The fertilizer math is even more compelling. India pays roughly ₹1.75 lakh crore annually in fertilizer subsidies, a significant portion of which flows to imported urea and its precursor, natural gas. Domestic urea production from coal gasification-derived ammonia would not only slash the subsidy burden but also insulate Indian farmers from global fertilizer price spikes — which doubled and tripled during 2021-23. India's Current Account Deficit (CAD) is fundamentally an energy import problem. Reducing energy imports by even 15-20 per cent through gasification-derived substitutes could save \$25-40 billion annually, transforming India's external balance sheet and materially strengthening the rupee. For RBI managing currency volatility driven by oil price shocks, this represents genuine macroeconomic stability.

How gasification fuels India's \$5 trillion dream

India's ambition to become a \$5 trillion economy and eventually a \$10 trillion economy by 2035 requires a GDP growth rate of 7-8 per cent annually. At those growth rates, energy demand will roughly double by 2035. The question is not whether India needs more

energy; the question is where it comes from. Energy import costs that scale with GDP growth will act as a brake — sucking out foreign exchange, widening the current account deficit, and reducing the real purchasing power of growth.

Coal gasification represents a GDP multiplier opportunity on three levels. First, import substitution ensures every dollar of energy and chemicals produced domestically rather than imported is a dollar retained in the Indian economy, circulating through wages, taxes, and reinvestment. At \$30-40 billion in potential annual import substitution, the macroeconomic gain is significant. Then comes industrialisation, cheap, domestically produced syngas, methanol, and chemicals lower the input costs for Indian manufacturing, improving competitiveness against China and other export manufacturing hubs. Third is value addition: instead of exporting raw coal at \$80-120 per tonne, gasification converts coal into products worth \$300-800 per tonne equivalent a 3 to 10 times-val-

ue multiplication on the same resource. "A ton of coal burned in a power plant is worth roughly ₹7,000. That same tonne, converted to methanol and chemical feedstocks through gasification, can generate ₹35,000-50,000 in value. Estimates suggest a fully — scaled 100 MTPA gasification ecosystem could contribute ₹15-2.5 lakh crore annually in GDP, representing close to 1 per cent of India's current GDP. There is also an export dimension.

India could become an exporter of methanol, ammonia, and specialty chemicals to neighbouring countries — Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Myanmar — and eventually to global markets. South Korea and Japan have already expressed interest in blue ammonia.

The opportunity is clear — India has the coal, the market, the industrial demand, and the policy intent. We now have the mission to drive the agenda. Let's hope it flies.

The writer is a Global Thought Leader and a Futurist Served on the Board of Engineers India Ltd (Union Minister of Petroleum & Natural Gas)

Sensex climbs 117 points on fag-end buying

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices rebounded on Wednesday on fag — end buying and a sharp rally in blue-chip Reliance Industries. Markets recovered all intraday losses and ended higher. The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 117.54 points, or 0.16 per cent, to settle at 75,318.39. During the day, it tanked 671.44 points, or 0.89 per cent, to 74,529.41.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 41 points, or 0.17 per cent, to end at 23,659.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Reliance Industries rallied 2.83 per cent. Bajaj Finserv, Trent, InterGlobe Aviation, Axis Bank and Mahindra & Mahindra were also among the winners.

Bharat Electronics, Tech Mahindra, Eternal and Tata Steel were among the major laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 2 per cent lower at \$109 per barrel.

"Markets recovered from intraday lows, supported by selective buying in

Top Gainers	Top Losers
Reliance 2.83	Bharat-2.30
Bajaj 1.33	Tech -1.85
Finserv 1.02	Mahindra -1.52
Trent 0.99	Eternal -1.08
Axis Bank 0.98	Hind Unilever -1.01

large-cap stocks across autos, financials, and oil & gas," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

However, persistent rupee weakness and elevated crude prices continue to weigh on sentiment due to concerns

around inflation and margin pressures, while FII flows remain mixed, he added.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower. Markets in Europe were trading higher. US markets ended lower on Tuesday.

US President Donald Trump on Tuesday said he was an hour away from making a decision to restart attacks on Iran, but put it off after receiving a call from interlocutors, including Qatar and the UAE, on Tehran being "reasonable" in the peace talks.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹2,457.49 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

On Tuesday, the Sensex declined 114.19 points, or 0.15 per cent, to settle at 75,200.85. The Nifty dipped 31.95 points, or 0.14 per cent, to end at 23,618.

Central Bank of India to open 150 branches, recruit about 1,400 officers in FY27: MD

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Central Bank of India plans to open 150 branches across the country and also increase its headcount by about 1,400 during the ongoing fiscal to meet its growth target, the bank MD and CEO Kalyan Kumar said.

The bank currently has 4,585 branches across all 28 states and six of the seven Union Territories. About 65 per cent of the bank's branches are in rural and semi-urban areas of the country.

"As far as branch expansion is concerned, we are going to open about 150 branches in the current fiscal and for which we have obtained approval from the board," he told PTI in an interview.

Speaking on human resources argumentation, Kumar said, human asset is the most important driver of business and the bank is going to add a good number of officers and employees to help in achieving Central Bank of India's targets.

The Mumbai — based lender has a total staff strength of about 34,000. Of

this 21,000 are officers and remaining are in clerical cadre. Talking about plans for the current financial year, he said the bank intends to hire about 1,000 Probationary Officers, 300 marketing officers, 50 forex officers and 15 AGM level officers in the area of risk management, forex and treasury.

The bank recently onboarded 1,000 credit officers to give push to quality credit underwriting, he said, adding, these officers are currently undergoing a rigorous training process.

Asked about revamp plans of Central Bank of India's subsidiaries, he said, the bank has two entities — Centbank Financial Services Ltd (CFSL), Cent Bank Home Finance Limited (CBHFL).

CFSL is wholly-owned subsidiary while the bank has 64 per cent stake in housing finance entity.

"We are strengthening the team in CBHFL and we have sent our General Manager as head and also 3-4 senior officers to improve governance and business," he said.

ally a core strength of this organisation, he said, adding, "We are working with our team members so that these subsidiaries can really achieve their potential. We are confident decent growth in these subsidiaries would be visible with the changes made this year."

In a bid to expand international banking business, Central Bank of India is all set to operationalise IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) at GIFT City in Gandhinagar in the first week of next month.

The bank has received regulatory approvals from the Reserve Bank of India and the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) to set up an

IBU, he said. The public sector lender has already posted a branch head and ground-work is in progress there, according to Kumar.

"We would be in a position to open our IBU branch by the first week of next month. The bank would certainly mobilise a good amount of forex business," he said. Emphasising that the opening of IBU will be a significant milestone in the bank's growth story, Kumar said, this will help expand international banking business and also enable the Central Bank of India to provide specialised banking services to customers.

The IBU will provide the bank access to international financial markets and allow it to deliver a complete range of products to its corporate clients with foreign currency funding requirements, Kumar said.

The bank will offer a suite of services, including foreign currency loans, trade finance solutions, treasury and risk management products, and enhanced convenient banking solutions to its customers, he added.

Rupee slips 13 paise to hit fresh lifetime low

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)
13	95.64
14	95.66
15	95.81
18	96.20
19	96.52
20	96.52*

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Declining for the ninth consecutive session, the rupee depreciated 13 paise to close at a fresh lifetime low of 96.83 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday as elevated global crude prices amid the West Asia crisis stoked inflation worries.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 96.89 against the US dollar, then lost further ground to touch a record low of 96.95 and a high of 96.65, before settling at 96.83 (provisional), registering a fall of 13 paise over its previous close.

In the previous session, the rupee tumbled 50 paise to settle at 96.70 against the dollar. "Indian rupee hit fresh lows on a strong dollar and a surge in US treasury yields. US 30-year treasury yields rose to a two-decade high, while the 10-year yields rose to a 16-month high.

"This led to inflation worries and sell-off in global markets, making the markets risk-averse," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Commodities

Research at Mirae Asset Sharekhan. "We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on risk aversion in the global markets amid inflation worries. A strong dollar and rising US Treasury yields raised inflation concerns and trimmed rate cut expectations. USD/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹96.5 to ₹97.10," he added.

The rupee's sharp decline has emerged as one of the biggest economic warning signs for policymakers, investors and businesses. Once considered among Asia's more stable currencies, the rupee has now become one of the worst-performing emerging market currencies this year, pressured by a toxic mix of expensive oil, capital outflows, widening trade deficits and a surging US dollar. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.42, higher by 0.09 per cent. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading down 2.77 per cent at \$109.95 per barrel in futures trade.

BY ORDER OF THE TRIBUNAL
SECTION OFFICER, DRT-II, DELHI

Xi calls for immediate end to all hostilities in West Asia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Wednesday called for an immediate end to hostilities in West Asia, saying the situation had reached a “critical juncture”, as he held talks with his Russian counterpart Vladimir Putin amid escalating regional tensions.

Welcoming Putin at the Great Hall of the People, Xi said renewed fighting in the Gulf and the wider West Asia must be avoided and stressed that negotiations should continue.

An early end to the conflict will help ease disruptions to energy supplies, industrial and supply chains, and the international trade order, the Chinese president said.

The talks between Xi and Putin came days after US President Donald Trump visited China from May 14-15 and held extensive discussions with the Chinese leader on the Iran-Israel conflict, the Strait of Hormuz and bilateral trade frictions.

The meeting is being closely watched as both China and Russia are key strategic partners of Iran with close economic and military ties to Tehran and could influence its tough stand on the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which has triggered a major global energy crisis.

Xi described the international situation as “fluid and turbulent” and, in an apparent criticism of Trump’s policies, said that “unilateralism and hegemonism are resurg-



Russian President Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping inspecting an honor guard during a welcoming ceremony in Beijing, China

ing”. “Yet peace, development and cooperation remain the aspiration of the UN Security Council and important major countries in the world, China and Russia should take a strategic and long-term perspective, drive the development and revitalisation of our respective countries through comprehensive strategic coordination of even higher quality, and work to make the global governance system more just and reasonable,” he said. According to

the Kremlin, around 40 deals are expected to be signed during Putin’s visit. Putin, who is making his 25th visit to China, described Xi as his “dear friend” and highlighted the close coordination and cooperation between the two strategic partners.

“Dear Mr President, Mr Xi Jinping, dear friend! It would be appropriate to use a Chinese saying: as far as we know, people in China say, ‘One day apart feels like three autumns’,” Russian news agency Tass quoted Putin as saying in his opening remarks.

“We are really happy to see you, and we constantly synchronise watches — both personally and through our aides,” he said.

The two leaders also agreed to further extend the China-Russia Treaty of Good-

Neighbourliness and Friendly Cooperation, signed 25 years ago. Xi said the treaty had laid the institutional foundation for long-term friendship and comprehensive strategic coordination between the two countries, adding that bilateral ties had achieved “leapfrog development” since then. “China supports the further extension of the treaty,” Xi said, adding that Beijing will work with Moscow to uphold the spirit of the agreement and firmly advance China-Russia “back-to-back strategic coordination”.

Ahead of the talks, Putin was accorded a ceremonial welcome by Xi.

The Russian leader, who arrived in Beijing on Tuesday night, was received by Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi. In a video message issued ahead of his visit, Putin said Russia-China ties had reached an “unprecedented level” and noted that bilateral trade had crossed USD 200 billion, with transactions increasingly being conducted in roubles and yuan.

He also said the Russia-China strategic partnership played a “major stabilising role” globally and stressed that the two countries would continue coordination through multilateral forums such as the United Nations, Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and BRICS.

Putin’s visit comes amid heightened tensions in West Asia following Iran’s blockade of the Hormuz and the US seizure of Iranian ports. (PTI)



Chief of the Air Staff Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh with air force officials during his visit, in Sri Lanka

Two Indian-origin scientists receive South Africa’s highest civilian honour

FAKIR HASSEN ■ Johannesburg

Two of South Africa’s internationally-recognised, Indian-origin scientists were among the 38 people awarded the country’s highest civilian awards in recognition of their outstanding contributions toward public health.

Professor Salim Abdool Karim and Professor Keertan Dheda, were formally awarded the prestigious Order of Mapungubwe by President Cyril Ramaphosa at Pretoria.

This specific order recognises South African citizens who have achieved excellence and exceptional accomplishment to the direct benefit of South Africa and the global community.

The citation for Karim, who was awarded the Order of Mapungubwe in Gold, honours



his monumental contributions to medical science and public health, particularly his groundbreaking research into HIV/Aids and tuberculosis (TB) epidemiology, and his exceptional leadership in national health policy development. (PTI)

4 militants killed in clash between two rival groups in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

At least 14 militants were killed and several others injured in a clash between rival armed groups in Pakistan’s northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Wednesday, police said. According to a police officer, fighting erupted between groups led by militant commanders Kazim and Mumtaz Imti in the Manato Kamran Killay area of Central Kurram district, bordering Afghanistan.

Commander Mumtaz Imti was killed during the exchange of fire, the officer said. After the clash, locals buried the bodies in the area.

Authorities said multiple operations have been conducted in Central Kurram amid reports of the presence of several militant factions in the region.

During these operations, security forces destroyed militant training centres and hideouts, and killed hundreds of militants, they added.



Finnish divers recover remaining two bodies of Italians

MOHAMED SHARUHAAN/
KRISHAN FRANCIS
■ Male

Divers on Wednesday recovered the last two bodies of the four Italians who died deep inside an underwater cave in the Maldives last week.

The Italian divers had been exploring the cave in Vaavu Atoll last Thursday when they disappeared. The body of their Italian diving instructor was recovered outside the cave, and the Finnish recovery divers brought the bodies of two of the divers to the surface Tuesday.

Presidential spokesperson Mohamed Hussain Shareef said the last two bodies were recovered by three Finnish divers supported by the Maldives coastguard and police. The bodies were taken to a morgue and were identified as Muriel Oddenino and Giorgia Sommocal.

On Tuesday Monica Montefalcone and Federico Gualtieri were brought out, Government spokesperson Ahmed Shaam said.

The instructor, Gianluca Benedetti, was found near the mouth of the cave the day the divers disappeared. (AP)



India key partner, Estonia will be ‘very happy’ if PM Modi visits: FM

ASIM KAMAL ■ Tallinn

Estonian Foreign Minister Margus Tsahkna has called for more high-level visits from India to deepen bilateral ties and said Estonia would be “very happy” if Prime Minister Narendra Modi visits the northern European country.

In an exclusive interview with PTI, Tsahkna said Estonia is organising the Ukraine recovery conference in 2027 and hoped that India could also be part of the rebuilding process of the war-hit country.

“India is a very important partner for Estonia. Our scales are totally different, from 1.3 million people (Estonian population) to 1.4 billion (Indian



Estonian Foreign Minister Margus Tsahkna

population). India is also the largest democracy in the world.

Our president (Alar Karis) was in India in February for the AI summit. Our bilateral relations are increasing in

business terms,” the Estonian foreign minister told PTI. “Be it the defence industry, IT, or AI solutions, Estonia is the perfect place for investments.

We have the E-residency programme through which

Indian companies and people can become E-residents and be a part of our brilliant startup environment.” I see the economic growth of India and also the leadership of the Indian Government on economic development, which is something our companies are very much interested in,” Tsahkna said.

The E-residency programme grants foreign nationals a secure Government-issued digital identity. This allows entrepreneurs to establish and manage an EU-based company entirely online, streamlining processes like document signing, banking, and tax filing from anywhere in the world. The minister

said there is significant potential for expanding bilateral ties. “We see the global trend, India is playing more and more a leading role in the region. Estonia is the gateway for Indian companies to the EU markets. So both sides are interested,” he said.

Asked whether more high-level visits are needed to strengthen ties and if Prime Minister Modi could visit Estonia in the future, Tsahkna said his country would warmly welcome such a visit.

“Estonia would be very happy if PM Modi comes to the country. We would welcome his excellency warmly, and also the foreign minister (S Jaishankar) is

welcome. The more high-level visits to Estonia, the better,” he said. There has so far been no prime ministerial visit from India to Estonia.

Tsahkna said Estonia is keen to receive Indian business delegations along with political leaders.

“We expect them to come with business delegations because we can open many gates and many doors to them and guarantee that they would be welcome... I am expecting as many high-level meetings from India as possible,” he said.

Bilateral trade in goods between the two countries stood at 139.3 million euros in 2025, while trade in services was valued at 66.4 million euros last year. (PTI)

Shanghai attack injures 3, including 2 Japanese; China calls it isolated incident

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

A knife attack at a restaurant in Shanghai injured three people, including two Japanese citizens, the Chinese foreign ministry said on Wednesday, calling it an isolated case.

The ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said Chinese authorities were investigating Tuesday’s attack and that the suspect, whom he described as a person with a mental disorder, had been detained.

The two Japanese citizens, alongside a Chinese citizen, were sent to the hospital for treatment, he added. “I would also like to stress that the media outlets and individuals should not make groundless speculation or unwarranted associations,” Guo told reporters at a news briefing.

The attack occurred amid rising tensions between China and Japan. Ties between Beijing and Tokyo have been strained since Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi’s comment in November that any Chinese mil-



itary action against self-ruled Taiwan could be grounds for a Japanese military response. China imposed diplomatic and economic measures against Japan.

In April, the Chinese Embassy in Japan said it had received multiple threats and accused Japanese authorities of failing to take effective measures despite repeated reports to the police.

Torrential rain, floods batter China, 12 killed

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Beijing

Torrential rain and floods hit parts of China this week, killing at least 12 people and forcing tens of thousands of people to evacuate, State media reported.

State broadcaster CCTV reported on Wednesday five deaths and 11 people missing in Shimen County of Hunan province in central China after rain battered the region. A rescue operation is underway. By Tuesday evening, more than 19,000 had been relocated, Chinese official news agency Xinhua reported.

Xinhua said the county recorded a cumulative rainfall of 339 millimeters

(about 13 inches) within a 24-hour period ending at 7 am on Monday. One of its towns once received a rainfall of 240 mm (about 9 inches) within just a few hours, breaking historical records, it said. In nearby Hubei province, some streets were turned into rivers and rescuers had to deploy inflatable boats to help stranded residents. Some houses were flooded or collapsed, Xinhua reported. Three people were killed and four others were missing as of Tuesday morning, it said. CCTV on Tuesday also reported that heavy rain and floods have caused four deaths and left five others missing in Guizhou Province in southwestern China.



EU approves US tariff deal capping EU exports at 15% to avoid Trump July 4 clash

SAM MCNEIL ■ Brussels

The European Union approved Wednesday a tariff deal with the United States to cap tariffs on most EU exports at 15 per cent, avoiding a direct clash with President Donald Trump ahead of his July 4 deadline.

Fierce debates raged among the 27-nation bloc’s lawmakers and leaders, jeopardising the hard-won bargain governing the massive exchange of goods and services across the Atlantic Ocean between two of the world’s largest economies, now weathering dangerous fallout from the war in Iran.



President Donald Trump with first lady Melania Trump addressing the attendees from the Blue Room Balcony of the White House in Washington

Parliament, legislators threatened to block the trade agreement that European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen had struck last July with United States President Donald

Trump at his Turnberry golf course in Scotland, following months of bargaining in the wake of his administration’s global fusillade of tariffs. The handshake between von der Leyen and Trump initiated

months more of negotiations over details between Washington and Brussels, just as criticism within Europe of the deal spiked after Trump threatened to take control of Greenland, a semiautonomous territory of Denmark. He has backed away from the threat, at least for now.

“A deal is a deal, and the EU honours its commitments,” said the EU executive in a social media post welcoming the agreement.

European lawmakers had successfully insisted on adding protections to the deal in case the US backtracks or wavers on details, said Bernard Lange, the head of the parliamentary trade

committee. “If there is something going wrong, of course, we are self-confident to act on that,” he said.

Intense negotiations across the EU

The rough outlines of a deal are clear: a 15 per cent tariff cap on most European imports, while tariffs on US industrial goods would be reduced to zero. While the deal burdened consumers and businesses with a tariff increase from the previous average of 4.8 per cent, it also gave businesses certainty so they could plan ahead, a factor credited with helping Europe avoid a recession last year.

With the continued

closure of the Strait of Hormuz driving up prices as the war in the Middle East rages on, interest rates and inflation from Latvia to Louisiana, proponents of the EU-US deal argue that settling trade between them is crucial in a time of global economic fragility. The American Chamber of Commerce in Brussels said in a statement that it was “relieved” to see the EU reach a consensus on the deal. “The trilogue agreement is a sign that the EU is honouring its commitments under the deal,” it said, allowing Washington and Brussels to “move beyond tariffs” to tackle thorny issues like critical supply chains. (AP)

Multilateral military exercise Pragati 2026 begins in Meghalaya

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Multilateral military exercise PRAGATI 2026 commenced today at Umroi Military Station, Meghalaya, with the participation of 12 friendly nations, namely Bhutan, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, Philippines, Seychelles, Sri Lanka and Vietnam.

The contingents were accorded a warm and traditional welcome by the Indian Army on their arrival, reflecting India's rich cultural heritage and hospitality.

PRAGATI, which stands for Partnership of Regional Armies for Growth and Transformation in the Indian Ocean Region, is being conducted in the spirit of equality, friendship and mutual respect.

The exercise provides a common platform for participating armies to engage in professional exchange, learn from one another's experiences and build closer military-to-military ties.

The opening ceremony was attended by senior military officials and dignitaries. In his address, Major General Sunil Sheoran, Additional Director General of Infantry, Indian Army, welcomed all contingents and highlighted the importance of collective engagement in addressing contemporary security challenges.

He encouraged all partici-



pants to engage with openness, mutual respect and a willingness to learn from one another's experiences, while highlighting that the strengths and perspectives brought by each nation would contribute meaningfully towards achieving the collective objectives of the exercise.

The objectives of the exercise include enabling seamless coordination among participating nations in joint operations and identifying common areas of cooperation; sharing expertise and establishing an institutionalised mechanism for exchange of best practices evolved through individual

experiences; strengthening defence ties and camaraderie through joint training and cultural exchange; and evolving common concepts for management and sharing of intelligence in a multinational environment.

The two-week exercise will focus on counter-terrorism operations in semi-mountainous and jungle terrain.

The training programme will include joint planning exercises, tactical-level drills and coordinated operations designed to improve adaptability, endurance and tactical proficiency of participating troops.

Emphasis will be laid on physical fitness, discipline and coordination while operating in challenging conditions.

As part of the exercise, Indian technology and defence companies will showcase indigenous equipment and innovations under the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative, providing a platform for knowledge exchange and highlighting India's growing capabilities in defence production, innovation and self-reliance.

Exercise PRAGATI 2026 is expected to further strengthen military-to-military cooperation, deepen professional bonds and contribute towards a shared approach to common security challenges among regional partners.

Delhi Division sets record with installation of Kavach system on 300 locomotives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ghaziabad

In a major achievement for railway safety and modernization, the Delhi Division of Northern Railway has successfully completed the installation of the indigenous Kavach safety system on 300 locomotives at the Electric Loco Shed, Ghaziabad.

The milestone was achieved on May 16, 2026, with the successful completion of the 300th Kavach installation, marking a new record in the field of safety system implementation across Indian Railways.

Kavach, India's indigenously developed automatic train protection system, has emerged as a key component in enhancing railway safety.



The Electric Loco Shed, Ghaziabad has earned recognition for completing the 100th, 200th, and 300th Kavach installations at the fastest pace in Indian Railways.

The shed had earlier created another record on September 10, 2024, by completing the Kavach installation on locomotive number 30623/WAP-7 within a single day — the fastest such instal-

lation recorded in Indian Railways.

Apart from achieving installation milestones, the Ghaziabad shed has also contributed significantly to technical training and knowledge sharing.

It organized seven one-day training programmes on Kavach installation procedures for officers and supervisors from different railway zones and sheds.

According to railway officials, a total of 309 officers and supervisors from 71 loco sheds across Indian Railways participated in these sessions. The training programmes focused on installation techniques, operational procedures, and technical best practices related to the Kavach system.

Govt strengthens legal metrology verification infra: Joshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Food and Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi on Wednesday said the Government has strengthened India's legal metrology verification infrastructure and emphasised the importance of accurate measurement.

According to an official statement, the Department of Consumer Affairs on Wednesday commemorated World Metrology Day 2026, marking the 151st anniversary of the historic

Metre Convention signed in Paris on May 20, 1875.

The theme of this year's World Metrology Day is "Metrology: Building Trust in Policy Making". Joshi, in his virtual address, highlighted the vital role of metrology in ensuring fairness, consumer protection, scientific reliability and transparent governance.

Referring to this year's theme, the minister emphasised that "accurate and reliable measurements form the backbone of effective public policy, trade, health-



care, environmental protection and industrial growth". Joshi informed that the department has strengthened India's legal metrology

verification infrastructure by issuing 40 Government Approved Test Centre (GATC) certificates to eligible private entities. He highlighted several key reforms undertaken by the department.

These include the decriminalisation of minor offences under the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026, introduction of improvement notices for certain minor violations, and transition from a licensing regime to a registration-based system for improving ease of doing business.

PROSPECT

Ganga Acrowools Limited unveils Hand-Knitting Yarn Collection 2026

Ganga Acrowools Limited (GAL) hosted its 'Premium Hand Knitting Yarns Collection 2026' at Le Méridien, New Delhi, in collaboration with Heartbeats Premium Yarns.

The event brought together distributors, retailers, designers, self-help groups (SHGs), artisan communities and boutique entrepreneurs to celebrate India's growing premium handmade craft economy.

Speaking at the event, Amit Thapar, President, Ganga Acrowools Limited, said that knitting and crochet in India are evolving beyond winter wear into categories such as home décor, gifting, boutique fashion and designer collaborations.

He added that Gen Z consumers, social media trends and the rise of slow fashion are driving crochet and knitting as new-age avenues for entrepreneurship and self-employment. The event also highlighted GAL's community-focused initiatives through partnerships with NGOs and SHGs aimed at training and empowering women artisans.

CM Himanta reviews industrial projects in Morigaon, visits Zubeen Khetra memorial site

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dispur

Himanta Biswa Sarma on Tuesday visited multiple project sites in Assam's Morigaon district to review the progress of key industrial and infrastructure initiatives aimed at transforming the state into a major industrial hub.

During the visit, the Chief Minister inspected the proposed Mega Industrial Park project spread across 1,067 bighas of land in the Sipiri-Duruladubi revenue villages under the Jagiroad constituency. The project is being developed as part of the state Government's broader push to strengthen industrial growth and generate employment opportunities in Assam.

Dr. Sarma also visited Ahatguri in Morigaon district and reviewed more than 331 bighas of reserved



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma paying his tributes to Assam's eternal hearth and reviewed the progress of the development work underway at Zubeen Kshetra near Guwahati PIONEER PHOTO

Government land at Borbori, which has been earmarked for establishing various Government institutions and related infrastructure facilities.

The Chief Minister interacted with local residents during the

inspection and directed officials to ensure timely implementation of the proposed projects. Local MLA Pijush Hazarika, Assam Chief Secretary Ravi Kota and senior officials from concerned departments

accompanied him during the visit.

A major highlight of the tour was Dr. Sarma's inspection of the proposed Tata Semiconductor Assembly and Test project site at Jagiroad. The semiconductor facility is expected to play a significant role in boosting Assam's economy and creating large-scale employment opportunities in the region.

Senior company officials, including Project Director Ashish Mishra, briefed the Chief Minister on the status of the project. Dr Sarma instructed officials to ensure fast and efficient execution of construction activities to keep the project on schedule.

Later in the day, the Chief Minister visited Zubeen Khetra at Komarkuchi in Sonapur, Kamrup Metropolitan district, where he paid tribute to late Assamese music icon Zubeen Garg by lighting a cer-

emonial lamp at the memorial site.

He reviewed the progress of the memorial construction work and inspected the surrounding areas. The Assam Government plans to develop Zubeen Khetra into a culturally significant memorial and inspirational centre for future generations.

Officials informed the Chief Minister that construction of the boundary wall has already begun at an estimated cost of around Rs 3 crore as part of the project's first phase. Measures to prevent soil erosion in the surrounding areas have also been initiated. Dr Sarma directed officials to expedite the next phase of the project.

During his visit to Morigaon district, the Chief Minister also offered prayers at the historic Gobha Deoraja Charibhai Deosal Shiva Temple for the welfare, peace and prosperity of the people of Assam.

Assam Rifles, Indian Army conduct joint flood relief training in Agartala, Tripura

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Agartala

The Assam Rifles and the Indian Army conducted a two-day joint flood relief training exercise in Tripura to strengthen disaster response preparedness and improve coordination during flood emergencies in the state.

The exercise was organised with the objective of ensuring smooth and effective flood relief operations during natural disasters.

It focused on enhancing synergy, operational coordination, readiness and response capabilities between the two forces.

Troops from both Assam Rifles and the Indian Army jointly participated in a series



of disaster management drills and practised standard operating procedures related to rescue, evacuation and relief operations.

During the training programme, personnel from both forces used common

drills, equipment and operational procedures to ensure uniformity in execution and better coordination during real-time emergency situations.

Officials said the exercise significantly improved inter-

operability between the two security forces and strengthened their ability to undertake coordinated disaster relief operations whenever required.

The joint training exercise also reaffirmed the commitment of the security forces to providing timely assistance to civil authorities and ensuring the safety and well-being of people during natural calamities and other emergencies.

Tripura and several other northeastern states frequently face flood-related challenges during the monsoon season, making coordinated disaster preparedness exercises crucial for effective emergency response.

Mystery, silence and shadows: *The Midnight Therapist* 1st look goes viral

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The first look poster of the upcoming short film *The Midnight Therapist* has sparked massive curiosity online, with cinephiles and advertising enthusiasts alike intrigued by its haunting visual language and mysterious premise. Produced by ADSII Media and EDWORLD INC, the film stars Titus Upputuru and Keshav Bharadwaj in the lead roles and is directed by Titus Upputuru himself.

The poster, which dropped across social media platforms this week, has quickly become the subject of intense discussion for its unsettling atmosphere and emotionally charged

imagery. What has especially caught everyone's attention is Titus Upputuru appearing in the role of a farmer — a striking departure from the polished creative world he is usually associated with.

Dressed in earthy tones with a deeply weathered look, Titus appears almost unrecognizable, hinting at a layered and emotionally intense character. Equally intriguing is the shadowy silhouette of another man standing in the darkness behind him, adding to the mystery surrounding the film's narrative.

The poster carries the chilling tagline: "The night listens to everything." The line has already begun circulating widely online, with audiences speculating whether the film

is a psychological thriller, an emotional drama, or something far more haunting.

Known primarily as one of advertising's most celebrated creative minds, Titus Upputuru has spent years redefining storytelling in Indian advertising through emotionally immersive narratives and award-winning campaigns.

With acclaimed works such as Nip in the Bud, Parcel, Long Distance Love, Tumhaari Amma and Baggage, Titus built a reputation for blending cinema and advertising with remarkable emotional depth.

However, *The Midnight Therapist* seems to mark a significant new chapter in his artistic journey. Industry observers believe the film-

maker is now pursuing cinema with full passion and intensity, moving beyond branded storytelling into darker, more layered cinematic territory.

The first look poster suggests a film rooted in emotional conflict, mystery, and psychological tension. While the makers have remained tight-lipped about the story, the rural setting, the farmer's appearance, and the ominous silhouette have already triggered widespread theories online.

The pairing of Titus Upputuru and Keshav Bharadwaj has also generated excitement, with audiences eager to witness the chemistry between the two actors in what appears to be a deeply atmospheric narrative.

DAILY SUDOKU

	7	4				1		
3		8		1				6
		1	5					
7			3			2	5	
			4		5			
2	5				9			1
				4	9			
	3			9		5		7
		9			3	2		

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (20.5.26)

4	5	7	1	2	6	3	9	8
9	8	6	4	7	3	5	1	2
3	2	1	9	8	5	6	4	7
8	1	2	3	9	4	7	6	5
5	3	4	8	6	7	1	2	9
7	6	9	5	1	2	4	8	3
1	4	8	7	5	9	2	3	6
6	7	3	2	4	8	9	5	1
2	9	5	6	3	1	8	7	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

THURSDAY | MAY 21, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9			10		
	11		12			
13		14		15	16	17
20		21				
22				23		
		24		25		
26	27	28		29		30
31			32		33	
		34			35	
36				37		
		38				

ACROSS

1 Might it make a poker player affluent? (5)

8 No longer hired as a woodman (5)

10 Informal (and informative?) entertainment (5)

11 Good when used for cooking (3)

12 Refers to punishment that finishes men in the ring (5)

13 Garments for show? (7)

15 Curse that combination bottle opener and salt shaker! (5)

18 Unit of nuclear energy? (3)

19 If duller, a gloss finish is poorer (6)

21 Hairy, but not necessarily dangerous (7)

22 We have a right to deteriorate (4)

23 Could have been spent in old Ireland (4)

24 Recover or obtain properly (3,4)

26 She romps, but doesn't exactly toy with a lad (6)

29 Also called "each way" (3)

31 Sober, but said to be out to start trouble (5)

32 The payload can be something alarming, out East (7)

34 To one fellow, looked in harmony (5)

35 Born in a bygone era (3)

36 Moisten a garden plot two ways (5)

37 Easily grasped by many a listener (5)

38 A hunted creature, one imagines (5)

17 Honesty in a letter to a girl (5)

19 Might he be wasted outright? (7)

20 Being smart, strikes! (5)

21 As played by Hank and a master? (5)

23 Play around in Leatherhead, obviously (7)

24 Work for the county and get demoted (2,4)

25 Make to last less than a weekend (3)

27 As a bit of a rotter, may be hounded (5)

28 But they don't hurt the angler (5)

30 A bad peach is of little worth (5)

32 Be afraid of a noisy lug (4)

33 Could you whiz after it with an excited cry? (3)

DOWN

1 Produce by spadework? (3,2)

2 Be hopeless at naming twins (7)

4 Lives heartlessly by deception (4)

5 Steady but, being old, about to start badly (6)

6 A greeting for one you hadn't expected? (7)

7 Friendly with Glenn? (5)

9 Somewhat up-market animal? (3)

12 Did this star show inquisitiveness about stewed eels? (7)

14 To growl at an egghead is the wrong thing to do (3)

16 Terrible flaw in staggering round the bend (5)

15, Mar-i-e

16,Pokes

18, Sp-in-y

19, R-ever-le

21, Operas

22, Blotto

23, Travel

25, After(-s)

26, Ba-W-d

28, Sub (rev.)

15, Mar-i-e

16,Pokes

18, Sp-in-y

19, R-ever-le

21, Operas

22, Blotto

23, Travel

25, After(-s)

26, Ba-W-d

28, Sub (rev.)

SOLUTION (20.5.26)

ACROSS

1, S-A-i-adj

6, D-airly

9, M-igret

10, P-le-adj

11, Voice

12,Denim

15, Rev-OK-Ed

16, W-E-P

17, Op-E-N

18, S-date

19,Ramps

20, Totter

22, Bit-e

24, Spa

25, Anglers

26, Beely

27, Fria-r

28, Slave(Vesta)

29, Wipe out

30, Aside

31, Bowls

DOWN

2, Asle-eP

3, Amazon

4, Dad (rev)

5, O-gle-d

6, De-vice

7,A-tom

8, Backet

25, Ba-W-d

13, Roots

14, Vesta

BRIEFLY

Fakhar, Saim not available for ODIs against Australia



Pakistan openers Fakhar Zaman and Saim Ayub will not be available for the upcoming three-match ODI series against Australia starting May 30 due to injuries.

The Pakistan Cricket Board on Wednesday said both the players are have been advised rehabilitation programmes under the supervision of a PCB medical panel. The first ODI against Australia will be held in Rawalpindi, followed by games in Lahore on June 2 and 4.

The board didn't elaborate on the nature of their injuries or the expected recovery time. However, a source said they had knee and ankle issues. The experienced Fakhar has, in the past, missed matches because of his chronic knee problem while Saim is said to have again injured his ankle during the Pakistan Super League. Saim had fractured his right ankle while fielding during the second Test against South Africa in January last year and made a comeback to the national side after several months.

He struggled for form in the PSL and was not a part of the ODI squad that played in Bangladesh after the T20 World Cup.

PTI

Southampton expelled from Championship playoffs



Southampton was expelled from the Championship playoffs on Tuesday after admitting to repeatedly spying on opponents. The English Football League reinstated Middlesbrough to play in the Wembley final – the richest game in soccer – against Hull City on Saturday. The winner gets promoted to the Premier League.

Southampton was charged earlier this month for a breach of league regulations, accused of the unauthorized filming of Middlesbrough's practice sessions ahead of their semifinal. It went on to win the two-legged tie to go within one game of promotion to the top flight.

The league said the southcoast club had subsequently admitted further breaches this season concerning games against Oxford United and Ipswich. It was also deducted four points for next season.

AP

Bangladesh beats Pakistan to complete 2-0 test series sweep



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Sylhet (Bangladesh)

Taijul Islam finished with six wickets as Bangladesh dismissed Pakistan for 358 on Wednesday for a 78-run win in the second cricket Test and a 2-0 sweep of the series.

The left-arm spinner took two of the three wickets to fall on Day 5 and returned 6-120 from 34.2 overs, clinching the series after helping reduce the tourists to 316-7 on Day 4.

Pakistan added 42 runs on the fifth morning before losing three wickets without addition to the total in 13 deliveries as Bangladesh rushed to victory.

"Our bowlers did a great job in hot conditions, on a flat wicket," Bangladesh captain Najmul Hossain Shanto said.

"In the batting sometimes (in the past) we lost too many wickets, but nowadays we have brilliant partnerships. Our tailenders also contribute a lot. Those are

the things we wanted to improve and I hope we continue."

Bangladesh won the first Test by 104 runs.

The victory marked Bangladesh's second successive series sweep against Pakistan, having previously completed a 2-0 victory in 2024. The end of Mohammad Rizwan's defiant, 166-ball innings signaled the end of Pakistan's hopes of chasing down an improbable victory target of 437.

Rizwan (94) struck Nahid Rana (2-71) for consecutive boundaries in the third over of the day to make Pakistan's intention clear. Sajid Khan also scored freely to maintain pressure on the bowlers from the home team.

But Taijul's breakthrough, dismissing Sajid for 28, ended a 54-run partnership, marked his 18th five-wicket haul in test matches and hastened the result.

In the next over, Rizwan cut a Shoriful Islam delivery straight to gully.

It is for the PCB to decide on my captaincy: Masood

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Disappointed Pakistan captain Shan Masood on Wednesday said the country's cricket board will take a call on his leadership role in the red ball format after Bangladesh handed them a 0-2 rout in the just-concluded Test series.

Bangladesh defeated Pakistan by 78 runs in the second Test at Sylhet on Wednesday, as the latter is languishing at eighth in the nine-team World Test Championship table.

When reminded that under his captaincy Pakistan have lost 12 out of 16 Tests, Masood said his conscience was clear and had tried his best to get good results for Pakistan.

"I don't want to criticise or praise anyone. Why we are not doing well in Test cricket – I will sit down with the board and discuss this. As far as the captaincy is concerned it is for the board to decide," Masood said in the post-match press conference.

Masood said he didn't think much about individual performances unless the team wins.

"I can understand the emotions of the people with the result and I can only offer my sincere apologies for the loss



but we can't look at things emotionally and we have to find a way to do well in test matches," he added.

The 36-year-old, who has been Test captain since December 2023, said he would like to appreciate the people who had prepared the pitches for the two Tests in Bangladesh.

"The pitches were very good Test tracks. They were good for batting and had something in them for the spinners and also pace and movement. They were very good Test pitches," he said.

R Praggnanandhaa faces Romania's Bogdan-Daniel



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bucharest (Romania)

Second-placed Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa will take on Romania's Deac Bogdan-Daniel in the sixth round of the Super Chess Classic, a part of the Grand Chess Tour, seeking to break his run of draws, here.

After five rounds, Germany's Vincent Keymer (3.5 points) is in sole lead by half a point over a chasing pack that includes Dutch duo of Anish Giri and Jorden van Foreest, top seeded American

Fabiano Caruana and Praggnanandhaa.

Caruana joined the shared second spot by defeating Alireza Firouzja of France in his fourth round game that was pushed back to the rest day as the latter suffered an ankle injury.

Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France and Wesley share the sixth spot on 2.5 points each while World Championship challenger Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan are right behind on two points. Romanian Bogdan-Daniel is in ninth spot on 1.5 points, half point ahead of Firouzja.

Arsenal wins first Premier League title in 22 years

JAMES ROBSONAP ■ London

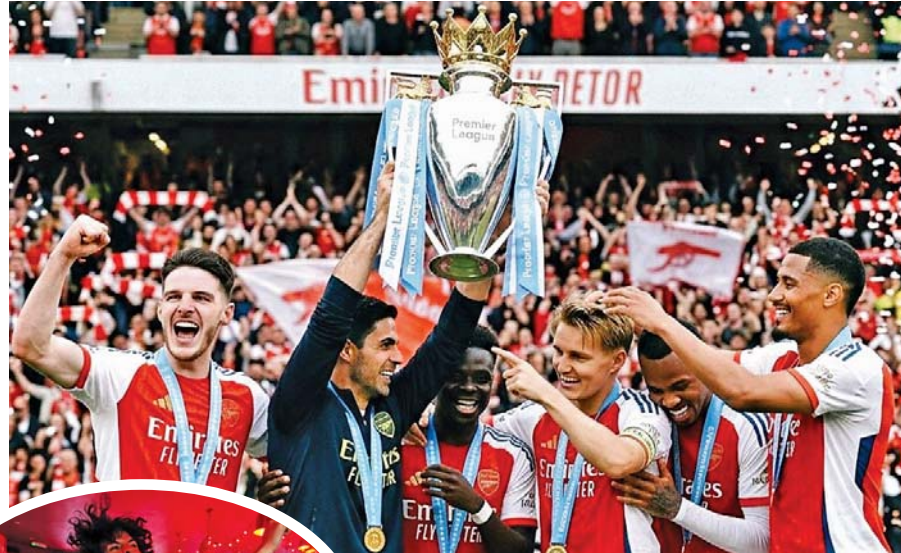
Arsenal's decades-long wait is over. Mikel Arteta's team was crowned Premier League champion for the first time since 2004 on Tuesday after Manchester City drew 1-1 with Bournemouth.

"I told you all... it's done," Arsenal midfielder Declan Rice posted on social media with a photo of he and his teammates celebrating.

The result put an end to what might be Pep Guardiola's final title challenge with City after the decorated manager didn't dismiss reports he was set to leave the club at the end of the season.

City needed to win at Bournemouth to take it down to the final game of the campaign on Sunday. But the draw left Arsenal with an unassailable four-point lead at the top, ending its 22-year wait for the title.

Arsenal fans celebrated wildly outside its Emirates Stadium, setting off flares



and partying in the street.

There were celebrations at the club's training ground, too, where the players had gathered to

watch the match.

City threatened another twist in an engrossing title race when Erling Haaland scored in stoppage time to equalise after Junior Kroupi's first-half strike, but it was too late to find a winner.

Arteta's players can now stand alongside club icons Thierry Henry, Dennis

Bergkamp and Ian Wright, who previously reached the summit of English soccer. And Arsenal's current class could yet break new ground by winning the Champions League for the first time in its history later this month.

Thoughts of the May 30 final against defending champion Paris Saint-Germain can be put on the backburner for now.

AP

The painful irony of Indian sport: Celebrating champions, abandoning athletes

AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

For years, India has celebrated sport in flashes. An Olympic medal here, a historic world title there, a stirring anthem at a distant arena that briefly unites millions.

Then, almost as quickly, the applause fades.

The spotlight swings back to cricket, the headlines return to IPL auctions and sponsorship battles, and athletes from other disciplines quietly resume their struggle for recognition, respect and often, basic financial security.

That uneasy truth surfaced again recently: India's star badminton pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty spoke with visible disappointment about how the country does not celebrate badminton achievements enough

despite years of global success.

Soon after, veteran chess Grandmaster Abhijit Gupta revealed that an organiser delayed his prize money payment and that even the national federation was initially slow to intervene. In January this year during the badminton nationals in Greater Noida, players were forced to sleep on floors since the fee was not paid the by federation to the hostel.

Even during the domestic wrestling event, the arrangements were not as they should be in Gonda.

These are different stories from different sports. Yet the same emotion runs through all. The feeling that Indian sport still values athletes selectively.

These are not isolated incidents. They are symptoms of a



larger sporting culture that still treats non-cricket athletes as temporary heroes instead of permanent national assets.

To be fair, India has made undeniable progress. Government-backed schemes such as the Target Olympic Podium Scheme

(TOPS), the Target Asian Games Group (TAGG) and the ACTC Funds have transformed athlete preparation.

Elite athletes today travel with physiotherapists, nutritionists, psychologists and foreign coaches, support systems that

barely existed a decade ago.

But funding excellence at the top is only one layer of sporting development. The real crisis lies beneath it.

A sporting superpower is not built only by financing a handful of elite athletes.

It is built by creating an ecosystem where athletes from every discipline are identified, supported, and valued long before they become champions and long after they stop winning medals.

India still lacks that ecosystem.

Why China and USA excel at Olympics is because there is a system that positively influences the sport and athletes. This is despite the fact that the two major sporting superpowers have conflicting attitude, yet the ambition and purpose is no different.

In China, Ye Shiwen, the 2012

Olympic champion in 400m, was trained in swimming because her hands and feet were disproportionately large compared to her height. She was taken into the state-sponsored system and groomed. There is a system that creates champions.

China thrives on discipline, and repetition of technique: In USA, it's a well crafted system that aims at gradual progress. From small leagues to school leagues to getting sponsorships to moving to College and then the national governing bodies of respective sports deal with the promising athlete.

In India, the obsession with just cricket is not difficult to understand. Cricket mastered television early, built icons across generations and became commercially irresistible.

The Indian Premier League (IPL) turned cricketers into year-round celebrities and converted sport into entertainment on a scale no other Indian federation could match.

Cricket became India's dominant sport because it built an ecosystem that no other sport managed to create. A middle-class Indian parent can now imagine a stable life through cricket.

Most Olympic sports still cannot offer that certainty: Other sports never received that level of sustained storytelling or investment.

A badminton player may win a Super 1000 title, a wrestler may become world champion, a chess player may beat elite grandmasters, but outside major tournaments they disappear from mainstream conversation.

PTI

Switzerland picks Amdouni in World Cup squad

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bern

Switzerland forward Zeki Amdouni was picked in the World Cup squad Tuesday with less than one hour of playing time all season after a serious knee injury.

Amdouni's appearance at Arsenal on Monday as a late substitute for Burnley was just his third game off the bench this month since recovering from an ACL rupture last July.

A solid record of 11 goals in 27 national-team games helped Amdouni earn a place in Switzerland coach Murat Yakin's 26-man squad that should be favored in a group with co-host Canada, 2022 host Qatar and Bosnia-Herzegovina.

The 26 names were



revealed over two days in a social media campaign, with fans invited to find them hidden in a series of photographs of Swiss residents at their workplaces.

Granit Xhaka will lead the

team as captain at what is the 33-year-old former Arsenal and Bayer Leverkusen midfielder's fourth straight World Cup to extend his national record of 144 games.

Yakin made surprise picks with attacking options Christian Fassnacht and Cedric Itten, who each played just a handful of minutes for Switzerland since 2023.

Fassnacht, the 18-goal top scorer in the national league this season, and his Young Boys teammate, goalkeeper Marvin Keller, are the only players selected from clubs in Switzerland. Swiss champion Thun is not represented.

Inter Milan defender Manuel Akanji just won a Serie A title and Johan Manzambi will play for Freiburg in the Europa League final Wednesday against Aston Villa.

Manzambi made an instant impact against World Cup co-hosts in the United States last June.

Coco Gauff has a new mindset for French Open

ANDREW DAMPFAP ■ Paris

Coco Gauff has a new approach for her second time around attempting to defend a Grand Slam title. The American's strategy heading into the French Open – the clay-court major that starts Sunday and which she won a year ago – goes something like this: Don't think about it as defending something.

"I realize that the defending means nothing in a way," Gauff said. "I don't really look at it as defending anymore."

Gauff's first Grand Slam title defense at the US Open two years ago ended in the fourth round with 19 double faults. "At the US Open I was like, I need to defend, defend. When you're playing a tournament that you didn't



win, what is it called?" Gauff said recently in Rome. "That's why I just say now it's just another tournament: I won it last year. I'll try again to do it this year." I'm not going to be able to defend every year. I'm not Rafa."

Rafa, of course, would be

Rafael Nadal, the record 14-time French Open champion.

Gauff's first Roland Garros title came with a victory over top-ranked

Aryna Sabalenka in the final a year ago.

Just like last year, Gauff was the runner-up at the Italian Open – a major clay-court warmup for Roland Garros.

"There's a lot of positives I can take from this tournament and a lot I can learn from," Gauff said after losing the final in Rome to Elina Svitolina. "This week I experienced all the ups and downs of a tournament... I've been down, had the lead, lost the lead, I've been in the final, been down match point. I think I've experienced every scenario that can prepare me for Roland Garros."

AP

KKR beat MI by four wickets

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders defeated Mumbai Indians by four wickets in a rain-interrupted IPL match to keep their playoff hopes alive here on Wednesday.

Sent in to bat, MI, who are already eliminated from playoff race, struggled their way to a modest 147 for 8.

Earlier in the game, KKR bowling unit exploited the sluggish conditions to perfection as it choked Mumbai Indians to a modest 147 for eight, in their must-win IPL clash, here on Wednesday.

Opting to bowl under overcast skies on a tacky Eden Gardens pitch that had remained under covers, KKR reduced MI to 41/4 inside the powerplay with Cameron Green (2/23 in three overs) and left-arm pacer Saurabh Dubey (2/34) sharing two wickets apiece up front.

Green was exceptional on the field and with the ball, striking twice in the space of three deliveries to remove Ryan Rickelton (6) and Naman Dhir (0).

He then pulled off a stunning running catch from midwicket to dismiss Rohit Sharma (15) off Dubey just when the Indian stalwart was looking to break free.

MI went on to lose three wickets for six runs in the space of eight balls.

After a one-hour rain interruption, KKR's spin duo



of Sunil Narine and injured Varun Chakravarthy tightened the screws further, conceding just 14 runs in their first four overs bowling in tandem.

Narine, in particular, was menacing with his turn and

variable bounce, repeatedly troubling Tilak Varma, before taking the prized scalp of MI skipper Hardik Pandya (26; 27b) beating him with a delivery that drifted in and stayed low to crash into the stumps.

Narine had splendid figures of 1/13 that had 16 dot balls.

Chakravarthy was unlucky not to dismiss Tilak on 12 after spilling a return catch following a collision with wicketkeeper Angkrish

Raghuvanshi.

Raghuvanshi hurt his hand in the process and had to walk off the field, with Tejasvi Dahiya coming on as substitute.

Tilak, however, failed to capitalise on the reprieve, crawling to a 32-ball 20 before holing out to Anukul Roy at square leg off Kartik Tyagi on the short 60-metre boundary.

From 106/7 in 17 overs, MI however did well to finish well with Corbin Bosch scoring 32 not out from 18 balls with two sixes and three fours as they scored 41 runs in last three overs.

Green earlier triggered the collapse with the new ball.

Rickelton top-edged a short ball to Manish Pandey at point, while Dhir fell for a three-ball duck after Green repeatedly beat him outside off before inducing an edge.

The Australian all-rounder successfully convinced Ajinkya Rahane to review after the on-field umpire turned down the appeal.

At the other end, Dubey bowled probing lines and reaped reward when Rohit miscued an expansive pull, only for Green to complete another brilliant catch running across from midwicket.

Suryakumar Yadav attempted a counterattack, striking Green for successive boundaries and then whipping Dubey over square leg for a six.

Gujarat Titans eye top-two finish

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Eyeing a top-two finish to ensure a shot at Qualifier 1, Gujarat Titans will have their tails up when they face a flagging Chennai Super Kings side seeking to regain lost ground after a rather disappointing campaign, in their IPL match here on Thursday.

A top-two placement at the end of the league stage grants the teams two opportunities to reach the final.

Currently placed second with 16 points, the Titans are in a three-way battle alongside table-toppers Royal Challengers Bengaluru (18 points) and Sunrisers Hyderabad (16 points), and victory against CSK will vastly improve their chances of a top-two finish in the group phase.

A victory over CSK by a heavy margin could even push GT past RCB's (+1.065) net run rate, depending on other fixtures. And if SRH too win their final league stage game against RCB, the battle for the second spot will come down to net run rate. In this scenario, GT hold slight edge with their NNR (+0.400) being better than Sunrisers' +0.350.

On the other hand, with their playoff hopes inching closer to getting extinguished after a narrow loss to SRH, the five-time former champions Chennai Super Kings will seek to salvage pride in what could be their



final outing in this edition.

Ruturaj Gaikwad's men have been pushed to the brink of elimination and require

a victory along with other results to go their way to stay in contention for the last playoffs berth.

Going into the contest on the traditionally batting friendly strip at the Narendra Modi Stadium, Titans' captain Shubman Gill is in excellent form, and so is his opening partner Sai Sudharsan. For the opening pair, negotiating early swing and controlling the powerplay will be crucial against the CSK bowling attack.

The middle overs will likely feature a fascinating tactical battle, with GT's star spinner Rashid Khan testing a seasoned CSK solid line-up.

Shreyas one of main contenders for India T20 captaincy: Ponting



BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Punjab Kings head coach Ricky Ponting has backed his franchise captain Shreyas Iyer to lead India in the T20 format after the team moves on from Suryakumar Yadav, saying that he is at the top of his game and never been "more mature".

Suryakumar recently captained India to an unprecedented second World Cup title but his form has dipped drastically in the last 12 months and he has been far from his best even in the ongoing Indian Premier League.

"There are several contenders (for the captaincy job post Surya), but he's (Shreyas Iyer) one of the main contenders as far as I'm concerned. We saw at the start of the tournament just how good a T20 player he is and where he's at, both on and off the field right now," the Australian legend told PTI in an interview.

"He's a much more mature player than he's probably ever been in his whole career. He's completely on top of his game now," said the batting great.

The chatter around Shreyas being the next India T20 captain has grown in recent times, even though he is not a part of the national team. Punjab Kings' peerless run in the first half of the IPL also contributed to the buzz around him before the team dramatically lost six games in a row. But Shreyas' record as a leader has been nothing short of impressive. (PTI)

Sooryavanshi is going to be as feared as Gayle: Irfan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will instill the same fear in the bowlers' minds that West Indian marauder Chris Gayle had managed to do in his prime, according to former India pacer Irfan Pathan. Sooryavanshi, with 53 sixes in the ongoing IPL, is within touching distance of the record 59 that Gayle struck in the 2012 season.

On Wednesday night against Lucknow Super Giants, the 15-year-old Rajasthan Royals batter hammered a 38-ball 93 that was dotted with 10 maximums and seven fours. The brutal knock steered his team to a facile seven-wicket win despite being in pursuit of a steep 221.

"It is very difficult to stop him. In his first 10 balls, he was batting at a strike rate of less than 100, and by the end of the innings, he had scored 93 runs off just 38 balls," Pathan said on 'JioHotstar'.

"With 53 sixes, he is actually



going after Chris Gayle's record of 59 sixes, which has stood since 2012. As bowlers, we were always scared of facing Chris Gayle. Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is creating that same fear, and Gayle's record is definitely in danger," he added.

Another former India player Sanjay Bangar said he does not have words to describe Sooryavanshi's talent.



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

He is all of 15 but Vaibhav Sooryavanshi knows that if he plays long enough, he will be showered with accolades, something that should not make him waver from his pursuit

Malvika, Ashmita progress to second round; Lakshya, Prannoy out

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kuala Lumpur

India's Malvika Bansod and Ashmita Chaliha emerged as the lone bright spots on an otherwise disappointing day for the country at the Malaysia Masters Super 500 here, advancing to the second round with contrasting wins in women's singles.

Malvika, who is on a comeback trail after recovering from an ACL (anterior cruciate ligament) injury that required



surgery, fought back strongly to beat Germany's world No. 52 Yvonne Li 21-17 16-21 21-9, while Ashmita registered a comfort-



able 21-16 21-13 victory over Indonesia's world No. 56 Thalita Ramadhani Wiriyawan. Malvika will face Denmark's



eighth seed Line HÅ, jmark Kjaersfeldt, while Ashmita takes on Malaysia's Goh Jin Wei next. However, India also suffered

a string of early exits across categories. In men's singles, eighth seed Lakshya Sen, the brightest Indian prospect, crashed out after a shock 17-21 11-21 defeat to Indonesia's world No. 38 Moh. Zaki Ubaidillah. HS Prannoy, the 2023 Asian games and World Championships bronze winner, too bowed out after a marathon battle against Japan's sixth seed Kodai Naraoka, losing 17-21 22-20 22-24 in an 80-minute contest.

Kiran George retired while trailing 15-21 1-6 against France's

seventh seed Alex Lanier.

India's Tharun Manneppalli squandered a one-game advantage to lose 21-17 14-21 8-21 to Chinese Taipei's Wang Po-Wei.

In women's singles, Anmol Kharb fought hard before going down 21-13 16-21 19-21 to Denmark's eighth seed Line Christophersen KjÅrsfeldt.

India's mixed doubles pair of Ashith Surya and Amrutha Pramuthesh lost 13-21 18-21 to Indonesia's Bobby Setiabudi and Melati Daeva Oktavianti in the opening round.

Did Langer-Moody duo completely mess up LSG's combinations?

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

When Lucknow Super Giants assembled their support staff headed by former Australia coach Justin Langer and IPL journeyman coach Tom Moody, the expectation was that the franchise would finally graduate from being a talented but inconsistent side into a genuine title contender.

Instead, what unfolded through the season was a campaign riddled with confused selections, questionable combinations and a team that never quite appeared to know what its strongest XI actually was.

For long phases of the tournament, it seemed that head coach Langer and skipper Rishabh Pant were operating from different tactical playbooks. The



body language after defeats, the chopping and changing of personnel and the indecisiveness around batting positions all pointed towards a side searching desperately for clarity.

The biggest talking point naturally remained owner Sanjiv Goenka's decision to break the bank for Pant at Rs 27.50 crore. While Pant remains one of India's biggest cricketing brands and among the most impactful match-winners in contemporary Indian cricket, the move inevitably skewed the balance of the squad and perhaps left glaring holes elsewhere.

The most obvious deficiency was the absence of quality overseas fast bowlers. Save South African Anrich Nortje, who himself got only one game, LSG never truly possessed an intimidating foreign pace option capable of changing matches in the middle overs or at the death.

It left the burden squarely on an inexperienced Indian bowling unit.

SA20 helped South Africa develop squad depth like India: Du Plessis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former South Africa captain Faf du Plessis believes his country now has enough depth to field second or third-string sides like India thanks to SA20, which has helped in expanding the talent pool besides creating more opportunities for players globally.

"India can pick a second or third-string team because of their depth, and you can now say the same about South Africa," du Plessis told SA20 on his return after a broadcasting stint in the IPL.



With 21 South African players involved in IPL this year, including 17 picked initially through retention or auction, du Plessis said the domestic T20 competition helped fran-

chises identify talent beyond the country's established international names.

"People are finally seeing the depth of the talent pool in South Africa," he said.

Cummins executes plans with clarity: Mark Boucher

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Sunrisers Hyderabad captain Pat Cummins neither chases the game nor makes unnecessary changes and instead sticks to his plans while executing them with clarity, says former Mumbai Indians head coach Mark Boucher.

Cummins joined SRH after missing nearly half of the IPL group stage this year due to a long injury-forced layoff but showed no signs of rustiness, taking eight wickets so far in six matches while making sure his team remains in hunt of a top-two finish.